



Class Notes

Rise of the Messiah

Matthew 1-4

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Who is this man, Jesus, and what about him is good news? Matthew guides us through the beginning of Jesus' ministry, highlighting all the ways Jesus fulfills God's promise of a chosen one to rescue his people. Journey through Jesus' birth, baptism, testing in the wilderness, and announcement of the Kingdom of Heaven.

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Module 1: Introducing Matthew

SESSIONS 1-4

Get acquainted with Matthew's Gospel. Explore the 1st-century background and the literary design of the book to learn about its structure and themes.

Session 1: What Does “Gospel” Mean?

Key Takeaways

- Learning about the origin of the gospels and how they were put together helps us understand what Matthew is trying to tell us on Matthew’s own terms.
- The Greek word *euangelion* (“gospel,” “good news”), was used by others in the Roman world, like Caesar, to promote their own agenda. The good news about Jesus confronts these other gospels and offers a vision of God’s plan for the world.
- The gospels came into existence not as library archives but out of the life mission of actual communities of a persecuted religious minority.

Introduction to the Fourfold Gospel

Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John offer the earliest accounts of the story of Jesus, and they are based on the eyewitness testimony of the apostles.

The word “gospel” (Old English: “god-spel” = “good tidings”) comes from a Greek word (*euangelion* / *ευαγγελιον*) that means “good news.”

In the Greek and Roman world of the 1st century, when the Roman Empire ruled the larger Mediterranean world, the word *euangelion* had a clear set of associations that are well illustrated by a monumental inscription found in the Turkish town of Priene. It records an edict from Paulus Fabius Maximus, the Roman proconsul of Asia, issued in 9 B.C.E. The edict aligns the regional calendar with the Roman calendar, honoring Caesar Augustus by making his birthday the beginning day of the calendar year.



Wikipedia Commons [Adrian Farwell](#)

"Providence has ordered all things and set them in order by giving us Caesar Augustus, whom she has filled with virtue that he might benefit all humanity, and has sent him as a savior for us and our descendants, that he might end war and bring order to all things ... The birthday of the god was the beginning of the good news for the world ..."

Priene Inscription, text and translation from Victor Ehrenberg and A.H.M. Jones, *Documents Illustrating the Reigns of Augustus and Tiberius* (1955). Oxford. 82.

Notice that Augustus' birth is hailed as "good news" (Grk. *euangelion*), that is, the arrival of a new ruler and a new regime of "salvation" (Grk. *soteria*) that has brought peace, order, and "benefit" (Grk. *euergesia*, literally "doing of goodness") to the known world.

This is precisely the same vocabulary used by the earliest disciples of Jesus to describe the importance of Jesus of Nazareth and the story of his life and message, his execution at the hands of the Jewish and Roman authorities, and his resurrection from the dead into a role of cosmic authority.

Mark 1:14-15 NIV

¹⁴ ... Jesus went into Galilee, proclaiming **the good news** of God. ¹⁵ "The time has come," he said. "The **kingdom of God has come near**. Repent and believe **the good news!**"

Romans 1:2-4 Instructor's Translation

² **The good news** ... ³ regarding **the Son of God**, who descended from David in his physical lineage, ⁴ and who was **appointed by the Holy Spirit to be the Son of God in power through his resurrection from the dead: Jesus, the Messiah, our Lord**.

Matthew 1:20-21 NASB

²⁰ ... behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to [Joseph] in a dream, saying,
"Joseph, **son of David**, do not be afraid to take Mary as your wife;
for **the child who has been conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit**.

²¹ She will bear a son; and you shall call His name Jesus,
for **he will save his people** from their sins."

In the New Testament, the good news about Jesus focuses on his role as the divine son of Israel's royal line (of David), whose birth and death and resurrection all lead to his rise to cosmic authority.

The word *euangelion* is the most concise, one-word summary of this message and story. It appears 12 times in the Gospel narratives and 87 times in Paul's letters (the noun 66x and the verb 21x)! Romans 1:2-4 and 1 Corinthians 15:1-3 offer Paul's clearest definitions.

Both Jesus and Paul derived this important word from the prophetic poetry of Isaiah (Isa. 52:7-10), where the future arrival of God's Kingdom through the messiah is called good news (Heb. *bisser*/Grk. *euangelion*).

Isaiah 52:7-8 LEB

⁷ How delightful on the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news,
who announces peace, who **brings good news**,

who announces salvation,
who says to Zion, **"Your God reigns as a king."**

⁸ The voices of your watchmen!
They lift up their voices;
together they sing for joy;
for they clearly see Yahweh's return to Zion.

Isaiah 40:9 LEB

Get yourself up to a high mountain,
Zion, **bringer of good news!**
Lift up your voice with strength,
Jerusalem, **bringer of good news!**
Lift it up; you must not fear!
Say to the cities of Judah, **"Here is your God!"**

Psalms 96:1-2, 9-10 NASB

¹ Sing to Yahweh a new song;
sing to Yahweh, all the earth.
² Sing to Yahweh, bless his name.
Proclaim the good news of his salvation from day to day.
⁹ Worship Yahweh in holy attire;
tremble before him, all the earth.
¹⁰ Say among the nations, **"Yahweh is king!"**

This network of passages from the Hebrew Bible attaches the phrase "good news" to a royal announcement of Yahweh's rescue of his covenant people. After Israel's long history of covenant violation, God will come to rescue his people, renew the covenant, and send a faithful leader to guide his people so that they can finally be what God has called them to be: a nation of royal-priestly representatives to the nations.

Matthew's Portrait of the Good News

The Gospel of Matthew comes to us from the later 1st century C.E., and it offers a unique portrait of the good news story about Jesus of Nazareth. The arc of this story and its main themes would have been recognizable to 1st century inhabitants of the Roman Empire but also surprising and even shocking.

Matthew describes the birth of a divine King, presented as the Son of the one true God, destined to reign over the world.

Matthew 1:1 Instructor's Translation

The scroll of **the birth-beginning of Jesus Messiah,**
son of David, son of Abraham ...

Matthew 3:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And, after being immersed,
Jesus immediately came up from the water,
and look, the skies were opened for him,
and he saw **the Spirit of God** descending like a dove,
and coming upon him,
¹⁷ and look, **a voice from the skies was speaking,**
“This is my son, the beloved one,
in him I have delight.”

Matthew 28:18-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ And approaching, Jesus said to [his disciples],
“All authority in the sky and on the land has been given to me,
¹⁹ so then, when y’all go, **make disciples of all the nations,**
immersing them in the name of **the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,**
²⁰ teaching them to keep everything that I have commanded y’all;
and look, I am with y’all all of the days,
until the conclusion of the age.”

This king was known for his mercy, and he provided food for the poor and healing for the sick and destitute.

Matthew 4:23-25 LEB

²³ And he went around through all of Galilee, **teaching in their synagogues and proclaiming the good news of the kingdom and healing every disease and every sickness among the people.**
²⁴ And a report about him went out throughout Syria, and they brought to him all those who were sick with various diseases and afflicted by torments, demon-possessed and epileptics and paralytics, and he healed them. ²⁵ And large crowds followed him from Galilee, Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judea, and from the other side of the Jordan.

But, in a shocking twist, this story focuses on growing hostility toward Jesus from the authorities of Jerusalem and the Roman Empire, resulting in a guilty verdict that led to the most shameful execution possible.

Matthew 27:37-39 Instructor's Translation

³⁷ And they put above his head the charge against him in writing:
“This is Jesus, the king of the Judeans.”
³⁸ Then two robbers were crucified with him, one on his right and one on his left.
³⁹ And those who passed by shamed him ...

Matthew’s account highlights many times over that this shameful death was actually a self-sacrifice made by Jesus as an act of service and love for others.

Matthew 20:25-28 Instructor's Translation

²⁵ But Jesus, summoning, said to them,
“Y’all know that the rulers of the nations dominate them,

and the great ones flaunt authority over them.

²⁶ It should not be this way with y'all,
but whoever desires to be a great one among y'all,
he must be the servant of y'all ...

²⁸ Just as **the son of the human did not come to be served,
but in order to serve,
and to give his life-being as a ransom on behalf of many.**

This is the surprising, shocking, and subversive story of good news that Matthew has to offer. It's not simply locked in the past, as the risen Jesus makes clear in the last sentence of the story. The good news is ongoing, as the risen Jesus is "with us" until the completion of the world story.

Reflection Question

What reflections come to mind for you considering the cultural and religious environment that gave rise to the gospels?

Session 2: The Formation of the Gospels

Key Takeaways

- The Gospels are carefully designed theological biographies of Jesus that focus on his announcement of the good news about the arrival of God's Kingdom here on Earth.
- The gospel accounts are not merely historical records; they are designed to advance a claim that will challenge the reader's thinking, loyalties, and behavior.
- The four gospel accounts offer different perspectives and carry different emphases. But from the beginning of the Jesus movement, these differences have been celebrated as providing a fuller portrait of the good news about Jesus through their unity and diversity.

What Are the Gospels?

They are carefully designed theological biographies of Jesus that focus on his announcement of the good news about the arrival of God's Kingdom here on Earth. The gospel accounts are not merely historical records but are designed to advance a claim that will challenge the reader's thinking, loyalties, and behavior: The crucified and risen Jesus of Nazareth is the Son of David, that is, the Messiah of Israel, and the Son of God, that is, the divine Lord of the world. The gospel narratives (1) claim to faithfully represent the story of Jesus and (2) aim to persuade the reader to acknowledge Jesus as Lord and enter a community of his apprentices.

The titles of the four works tell us much about their purpose: "The Gospel according to ____." This tells us that Jesus' story is being framed in a unique way by each author for distinct purposes. We have evidence that these titles were being used in the early 2nd century C.E. to distinguish the gospel manuscripts from each other.

- For more on titles of the gospels in early New Testament manuscripts, see James Kelhoffer, "[How Soon a Book Revisited: ΕΥΑΓΓΕΛΙΟΝ as a Reference to Gospel Materials in the First Half of the Second Century](#)," in *Zeitschrift für Neutestamentliche Wissenschaft* vol. 95 (2004), p. 1-34.

Calling these books "the Gospels" derives from Mark's usage of the word in [Mark 1:1](#) "The beginning of **the good news** about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God."

The Gospel and Ancient Biography

The Gospels are a kind of ancient biography.

- See the work of Richard Burridge, [What Are the Gospels? A Comparison with Greco-Roman Biography](#), and Loveday Alexander, [The Preface to Luke's Gospel](#).

Biographies in the ancient world were:

- Representations of the essence/meaning of a key figure's life story and message
- Not archival, unbiased accounts but accounts aimed at persuading the reader to emulate the figure

“The four apostolic Gospels are theological, historical, and formational, narrative biographies that retell the story and proclaim the significance of Jesus as Israel’s messiah and the Lord of all nations, the one who through the power of the Spirit is restoring God’s reign over all creation.”

Pennington, Jonathan (2012). [Reading the Gospels Wisely](#). Baker Academic. 35.

The Formation of the Gospels

Events and Teachings ↘	4 B.C.–80s/90s A.D. — Jesus’ early life, mission in Galilee, teaching and healing, mission to Jerusalem, execution, empty tomb, resurrection appearances, Pentecost
Eye-Witness Testimony ↘	4 B.C.–80s/90s A.D. — The earliest communities of Jesus’ followers contained eyewitnesses, friends and family members of Jesus' disciples, people healed by Jesus, and those who encountered Jesus.
Oral Traditions and Written Traditions ↘	30 A.D.–mid 2nd century A.D. — Jesus’ teaching and stories about him circulated in church communities for decades
Collections of Traditions ↘	40s A.D.–70s A.D. — Collections of traditions grouped together in oral and written form (“Q” or special material in Matthew, Luke, early Mark)
Gospel Compositions	60s–90s A.D. — Mark, Matthew, Luke, John, extra-canonical gospel traditions (Gospel of Peter, Gospel of Thomas, etc.)

The Formation of the Gospels. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

For more detail on each stage of this important process, see the work of:

- Michael Bird, [The Gospel of the Lord: How the Early Church Wrote the Story of Jesus](#)
- James D.G. Dunn, [The Oral Gospel Tradition](#)
- Martin Hengel, [The Four Gospels and the One Gospel of Jesus Christ](#)

Main Theories of the Relationship Between the Synoptic Gospels

Charts adapted from Mark Goodacre, [The Synoptic Problem: A Way Through the Maze](#)

Priority of Mark Theories

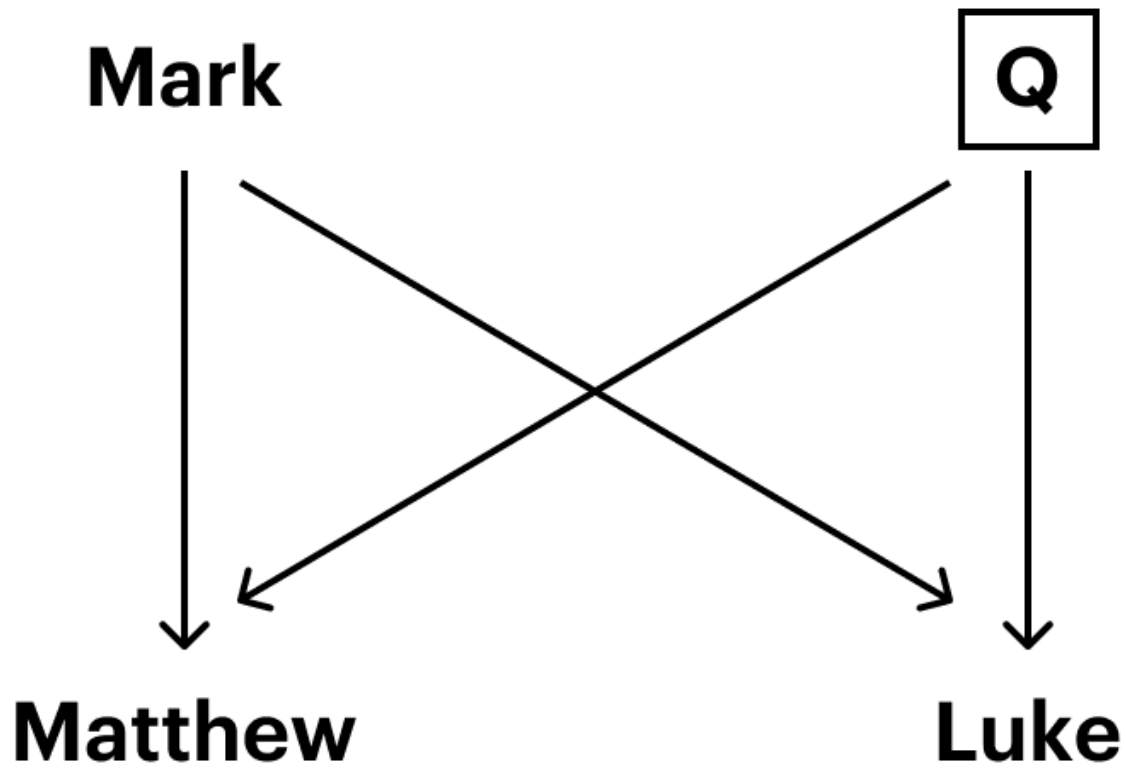


Fig. 1. The Two-Source Theory

The Two Source Theory. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The Two-Source Theory (Mark + “Q” + Special Matthew/Luke)

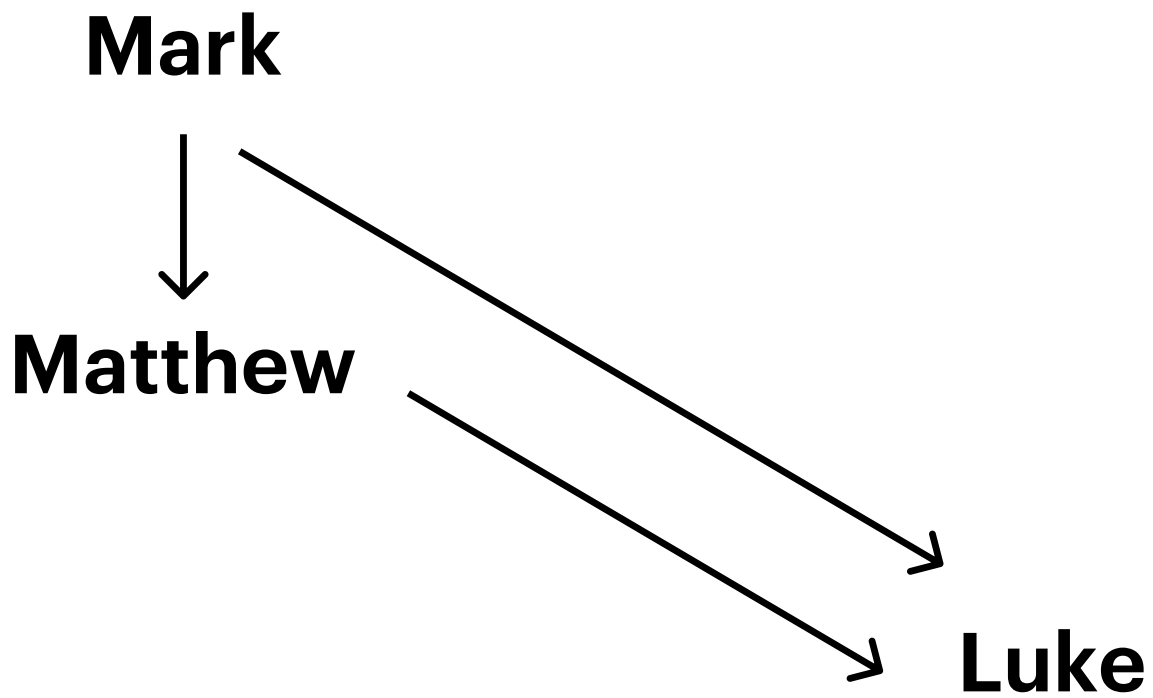


Fig. 2. The Farrer Theory

The Farrer Theory. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The Farrer Theory (Mark + Matthew used by Luke)

Priority of Matthew Theory

Matthew

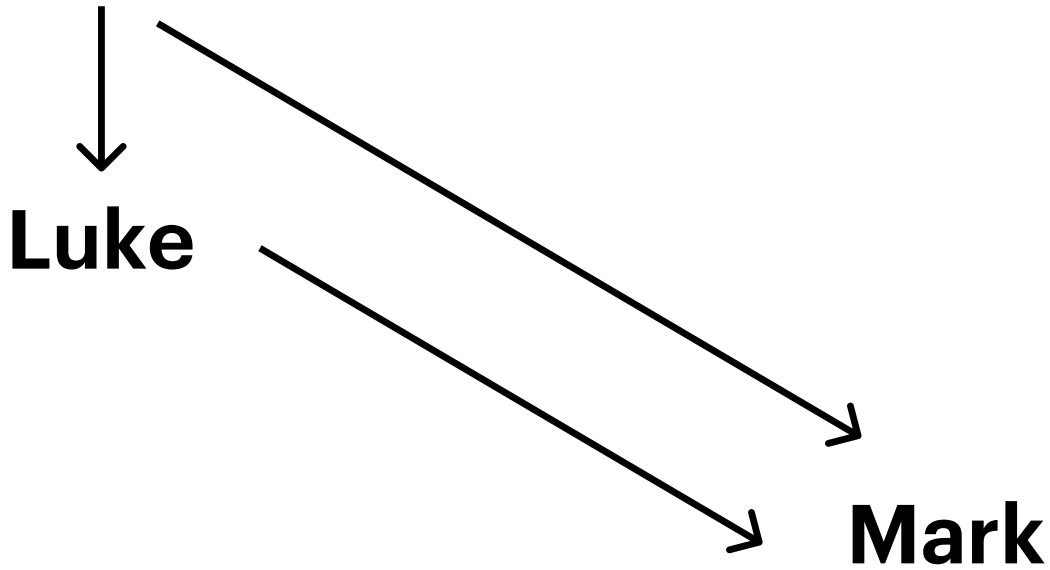


Fig. 3. The Griesbach Theory

The Griesbach Theory. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The Griesbach Theory (Matthew was the source of Luke, both abbreviated by Mark)

Reflection Question

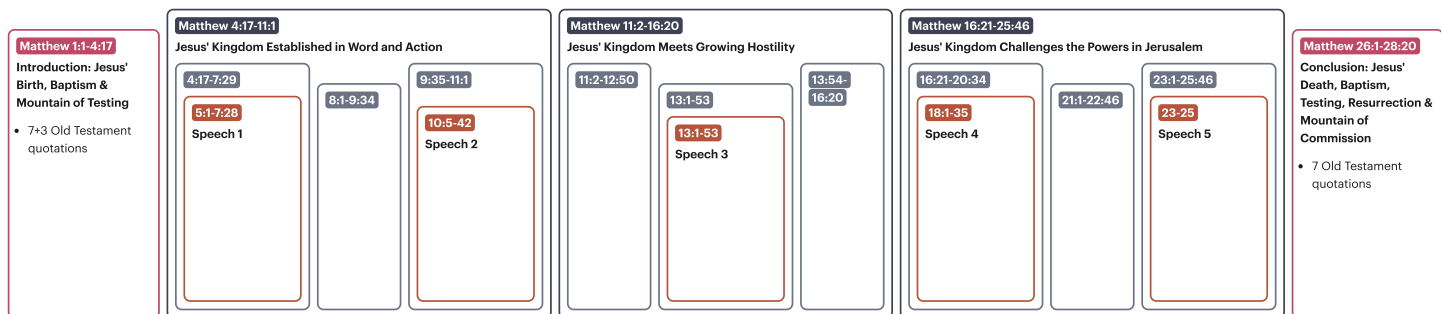
What is challenging for you about the differences in the four gospel accounts? What is encouraging or helpful?

Session 3: Macro Design of Matthew's Gospel

Key Takeaways

- Matthew structures Jesus' teaching to reflect the teaching of Moses, showing how Jesus came to fill full the Torah.
- Matthew identifies Jesus as the Son of David, emphasizing how Jesus is the fulfillment of Israel's messianic hopes.
- Matthew portrays Jesus as the Son of Abraham, emphasizing how Jesus is the fulfillment of God's promise of blessing to all nations through Abraham and his descendants.
- Matthew presents Jesus as the Son of God and Son of Humanity, focusing on the claim of Jesus' divine and human identity.

The Macro Design of the Gospel According to Matthew



Matthew 1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Matthew has carefully crafted his account with a matching introduction and conclusion.

- Matthew 1:1-4:17 introduces Jesus as the Son of Abraham, of David, and of God. He is born as a human, baptised and tested on a wilderness mountain, all marked by 7 + 3 quotations from Scripture (7 "fulfillment" quotes + 3 quotes).
- Matthew 26:1-28:20 brings Jesus' vocation as Son of David and Son of God to a climactic conclusion. He is tested in a garden, executed (= his "baptism"), resurrected, and then commissions his disciples on a mountain, all marked by 7 quotations from Scripture.

Between the introductory and concluding frames, Matthew 4:17-25:46 takes the story from Jesus' announcement of God's Kingdom (Matt. 4:12-17) to Jesus' final days in Jerusalem (Matt. 26:1-28:20). Matthew has organized this section in three large parts, the first and last of which have matching introductions that set the main theme for the unit.

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began (απο τότε ηρξάτο ο Ιησους)

to announce and say,

"Change-direction!

Because the kingdom of the skies has come near!"

Matthew 16:21 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began (απο τότε ηρξάτο ο Ιησους)

to point out that it was necessary for him to go to Ierosolima,

and to suffer many things by the elders and chief-priests and scribes,

and to be killed,

and on the third day, to be raised up.

These introductions are coordinated with the conclusions to the five matching speeches.

Matthew 7:28 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **these words ...**

Matthew 11:1 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when he finished (ετελεσεν) **instructing his twelve apprentices ...**

Matthew 13:53 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **these parables ...**

Matthew 19:1 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **these words ...**

Matthew 26:1 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Iesous finished (ετελεσεν) **all these words ...**

The five teaching blocks are all arranged in a symmetrical way and with matching themes.

Matthew 5:1-7:29 Sermon on the Mount in Galilee • 7:28 "When Jesus finished these words ..."	Matthew 10:1-42 Sending Speech • 11:1 "When Jesus finished instructing the twelve ..."	Matthew 13:1-52 Kingdom Parables • 13:52 "When Jesus finished these parables ..."	Matthew 18:1-35 Kingdom Ethics • 19:1 "When Jesus finished these words ..."	Matthew 23:1-25:46 Speeches in Jerusalem • 26:1 "When Jesus finished all these words ..."
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Matthew 5-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The opening and closing teachings are the longest, and they display matching designs and main themes, as summarized in the charts below.

Matthew 5:1-7:27		Sermon on the Mount	Matthew 23:1-25:46		Sermon about Jerusalem's Ruin
Matt. 5:1-16	Matt. 5:1-12	The 9 blessings on the disciples	Matt. 23:1-38	Matt. 23:1-12	The 7 woes on the Pharisees
	Matt. 5:13			Matt. 23:13-32	
	Matt. 5:14-16			Matt. 23:33-38	
Matt. 5:17-7:12	Matt. 5:17-48	Discourse on New Covenant righteousness	Matt. 24:1-50	Matt. 24:1-14	Discourse on the ruin of Jerusalem and the exaltation of the Son of Man
	Matt. 6:1-18			Matt. 24:15-35	
	Matt. 6:19-7:12			Matt. 24:36-50	
Matt. 7:13-27	Matt. 7:13-14	Three parables about the two ways: • Wide and narrow gates • Wolves and sheep • Stable house vs. unstable house	Matt. 25:1-46	Matt. 25:1-13	Three parables about the culmination of the ages: • Wise and foolish women • Wise and rebel slaves • Sheep and goats
	Matt. 7:15-23			Matt. 25:14-30	
	Matt. 7:24-27			Matt. 25:31-46	
Matthew Sermon Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).					

The three sections that make up the central body of Matthew advance the core themes and narrative claims made about Jesus.

1. Matthew 4:17-11:1 — Jesus is the Son of God, bringing the Kingdom of the skies down to Earth in word (chs. 5-7) and action (chs. 8-9) and then sending his disciples out to share in his mission (ch. 10).
2. Matthew 11:2-16:20 — Jesus' identity is developed and reacted to in different ways.
 - The disciples discern that Jesus is the Son of God.
 - The crowds come to see Jesus as the Son of David.
 - The authorities view Jesus as a deceiver and threat to be destroyed.
3. Matthew 16:21-25:46 — Jesus describes his identity as the Son of God come to suffer and die in Jerusalem for the sins of his people (chs. 16-20), so Jesus goes to the city (chs. 20-21) and engages the

Major Themes in Matthew's Gospel

Jesus, Son of David, Son of Abraham, Son of God

From the first line of the book, Jesus is introduced as a "son of David, son of Abraham" (Matt. 1:1), and not long after that, as "the son of God" (Matt. 3:17). These three aspects of Jesus' identity are uniquely highlighted and interconnected in Matthew.

"Son of David" = **Israel focused** : heir to Israel's royal and messianic hopes, as expressed in the Torah, Prophets, and Psalms. This is an Israel-focused role, so it explains the laser focus Jesus has in Matthew on his mission to Israel.

Matthew 1:20-21 NASB

²⁰ But when he had considered this, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, "Joseph, **son of David**, do not be afraid to take Mary as your wife; for the child who has been conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit. ²¹ She will bear a son; and you shall call his name Jesus, **for he will save his people from their sins.**"

Matthew 4:23 NASB

Jesus was **going throughout all Galilee**, teaching **in their synagogues** and proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every kind of disease and every kind of sickness among the people.

Matthew 10:5-6 NASB

⁵ These twelve Jesus sent out after instructing them: "**Do not go in the way of the nations**, and do not enter any city of the Samaritans; ⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.**"

Matthew 15:22-24 NASB

²² And a Canaanite woman from that region came out and began to cry out, saying, "Have mercy on me, Lord, **Son of David**; my daughter is cruelly demon-possessed." ²³ But he did not answer her a word. And his disciples came and implored him, saying, "Send her away, because she keeps shouting at us." ²⁴ But he answered and said, "**I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.**"

"Son of Abraham" = **nations focused** : the inheritor of the promise that, through Israel, God's blessing would go out to all nations. This is also a major theme in Matthew's Gospel because Jesus' launching of God's heavenly Kingdom on Earth was always meant to go out to the nations.

- Matthew 1:1-17: The four non-Israelite matriarches in Jesus' genealogy
- Matthew 2:1-2: The eastern astrologers who come to pay tribute and worship baby Jesus
- Matthew 8:5-13: The Roman centurion who bows before Jesus' healing power

Matthew 8:10-11 NASB

¹⁰ Now when Jesus heard this, he marveled and said to those who were following, “Truly I say to you, **I have not found such great faith with anyone in Israel.** ¹¹ I say to you that many will come from east and west, and **recline at the table with Abraham**, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven;”

- Matthew 15:31-39: Feeding a non-Israelite crowd with bread from Heaven

“Son of God and Son of Humanity” = **divine + human focused** : Matthew has combined the above two themes about Jesus’ identity (Son of David and Abraham) with a third unifying claim—in Jesus, the God of Israel has become personally present to bring God’s rescuing rule over both Israel and the nations. As the divine Son, he will surrender his cosmic authority in obedience to the will of his Father precisely so that he can identify with Israel and the nations in their sin-induced suffering and mortality. He will, after his death, be raised up to cosmic authority so that through the Son of David, the Messiah of Israel, the promise to Abraham of blessing for the nations can finally be fulfilled through a union of God with his people.

Matthew 1:22-23 NASB

²² Now all this took place to fulfill what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet:

²³ “Behold, the virgin shall be with child and shall bear **a son**, and they shall call his name Immanuel,” which translated means, **“God with us.”**

Matthew 3:16-17 NASB

¹⁶ After being baptized, Jesus came up immediately from the water; and behold, the heavens were opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending as a dove and lighting on him, ¹⁷ and behold, a voice out of the heavens said, **“This is my beloved Son**, in whom I am well-pleased.”

Matthew 17:5 NASB

While he was still speaking, a bright cloud overshadowed them, and behold, a voice out of the cloud said, **“This is my beloved Son**, with whom I am well-pleased; listen to him!”

Matthew 17:22-23 NASB

²² And while they were gathering together in Galilee, Jesus said to them, **“The Son of humanity is going to be delivered into the hands of men;** ²³ and **they will kill him**, and **he will be raised** on the third day.” And they were deeply grieved.

Matthew 18:20 NASB

For where two or three have gathered together in my name, **I am there in the middle of them.**

Matthew 28:18-20 NASB

¹⁸ And Jesus came up and spoke to them, saying, **“All authority has been given to me in heaven and on earth.** ¹⁹ Go therefore and **make disciples of all the nations**, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, ²⁰ teaching them to observe all that I commanded you; and look, **I am with you always, even to the end of the age.”**

Jesus, Moses, and the Messianic Torah

Matthew collects most of Jesus' teaching into five large blocks that are strategically placed in locations that symmetrically match on the macro-scale of the book. Each of these teachings concludes with the same phrase.

Matthew 7:28, 11:1, 13:53, 19:1, 26:1 NASB

And when Jesus finished (τελεω) speaking these words ...

Here, Matthew portrays Jesus on analogy with moments where Moses concludes a large delivery of covenant laws from Yahweh to Israel in the Torah.

Exodus 31:18 Instructor's Translation

And when he **finished** (συντελεω) speaking with him on Mount Sinai, he gave Moses the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written by the finger of God.

Deuteronomy 31:24 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Moses **finished** (συντελεω) **writing the words** of this Torah in a scroll until they were complete

Deuteronomy 32:45 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Moses **finished** (συντελεω) **speaking all these words** to Israel

In the Deuteronomy passages, it is Moses who has "finished" speaking the words of the Torah to the people. But notice that in [Exodus 31:18](#), the first instance of this formula, it is Yahweh who finishes speaking to Moses, who will go and speak to Israel.

It is no coincidence that Matthew has placed Jesus' discussion about "fulfilling the Torah" ([Matt. 5:17-21](#)) near the beginning of the first teaching block. Jesus is presented as bringing about what Moses himself longed for in the Torah, that God's people would love their God and live by his will from the deepest desires of their heart. This is a uniquely major emphasis in Matthew's presentation of Jesus.

Deuteronomy 10:12-13 NASB

¹² Now, Israel, what does the LORD your God require from you, but to fear the LORD your God, to walk in all his ways and **love him**, and to serve the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul, ¹³ and to keep the LORD's commandments and His statutes which I am commanding you today for your good?

Deuteronomy 30:6 NASB

Moreover the LORD your God will circumcise your heart and the heart of your descendants, **to love the LORD your God with all your heart** and with all your soul, so that you may live.

Matthew 22:37-40 NASB

³⁷ And he said to him, "'You shall **love the Lord your God with all your heart**, and with all your soul, and with all your mind.'

³⁸ This is the great and foremost commandment.

³⁹ The second is like it, 'You shall **love your neighbor as yourself.**'

⁴⁰ **On these two commandments depend the whole Torah and the Prophets."**

Matthew 23:23 NASB

Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you tithe mint and dill and cummin, and have neglected **the weightier matters of the law: justice and mercy and faithfulness**; but these are the things you should have done without neglecting the others.

Jesus and the Messianic Community

Matthew has presented Jesus as the Son of David/Abraham/God and as a messianic revealer of the new covenant and fulfilled Torah, precisely to begin a renewal movement in Israel that will grow to include the nations. This is not a replacement of Israel, it is a renewal of Israel into communities that will expand to include the nations.

Only in Matthew does Jesus explicitly refer to his "community" (Grk. *ekklesia*).

Matthew 16:16-18 NASB*

¹⁶ Simon Peter answered, "You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God."

¹⁷ And Jesus said to him, "Blessed are you, Simon Barjona, because flesh and blood did not reveal this to you, but my Father who is in heaven. ¹⁸ I also say to you that you are Peter, and upon this rock I will build **my assembly**; and the gates of the grave will not overpower it."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Matthew 18:17 NASB*

And if he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if he refuses to listen even to **the assembly**, let him be to you as a Gentile and a tax collector.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In both of these passages, Jesus is aware that he is beginning an "assembly" that has a unique social identity within Israel because of its association with himself.

The twelve disciples (= symbol of a renewed Israel!) are sent out by Jesus in order to take up his mission and expand its reach (Matt. 4:17).

Matthew 10:5-7 NASB

⁵ These twelve Jesus sent out after instructing them: "Do not go in the way of the Gentiles, and do not enter any city of the Samaritans; ⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.** ⁷ And as you go, preach, saying, '**The kingdom of heaven is at hand.**'"

Much of Jesus' teaching in Matthew is dedicated to ethical and social formation, so the community embodies the true fulfillment of Israel's Torah (chs. 5-7) and mirrors Jesus' own servant ethic (ch. 10 and ch. 18). Jesus anticipates that his assembly will include all kinds of people with all kinds of motives (ch. 13), which will all be sorted out in the transition from this age into the age to come (chs. 23-25).

Reflection Question

Matthew begins with a long genealogy. What themes are introduced here and developed throughout the rest of Matthew's Gospel?

Session 4: The Origins of Matthew's Gospel

Key Takeaways

- Ancient literature, like Matthew, is usually connected to authoritative figures, but they don't necessarily need to have written it to justify this association.
- Many of the earliest (2nd-3rd century) manuscripts of the gospels are titled "According to Mark/Matthew/Luke/John."
- The earliest Christian communities accepted this account as coming from the tradition of the apostles, channeled through Matthew.

Social Setting, Authorship, and Date of the Gospel According to Matthew

It's important to begin by saying that we have no certain or conclusive evidence regarding the most basic questions about the Gospel of Matthew.

- Who wrote it? The gospel is anonymous; nowhere does it name its author.
- When was it written? Nowhere is a date given in the gospel itself.
- Why or among what communities was it written? No related information is given within the gospel.

The Gospel of Matthew is not, however, unique when it comes to these questions. None of the four gospel accounts contains any explicit information about these things. Even the prologue to Luke ([Luke 1:1-2](#)) and the epilogue to John ([John 21](#)), which contain very precious information about the author and setting of the books, don't answer these questions directly.

Insight into these important questions takes place through a process of induction by reading the gospel itself (internal evidence) and by sifting through all of the earliest quotations or mentions of the Gospel of Matthew in the earliest generations of the Church. But, it turns out, there is a lot to work with on these fronts.

External Evidence About the Origins of the Gospel of Matthew

The Gospel manuscripts have their title "According to Mark/Matthew/Luke/John" in many of the earliest (2nd-3rd century) manuscripts.

Papias, an early 2nd-century bishop in Asia Minor, shares a memory he claims to have learned from the apostles.

"Matthew collected the sayings/matters in the Hebrew language, and each person translated them as he was able."

There is no scholarly consensus about what exactly Papias means, or whether his report is even accurate in the first place.

- While Jesus' words would have been translated from Aramaic into Greek at a pre-Gospel stage, there is no evidence that Matthew is the result of such a process. The original language of the Gospel of Matthew was certainly in Greek, based on the simple fact that some 80% of Mark's Greek account is taken up and edited by Matthew (Mark's Greek reads much more like Hebrew written in Greek, whereas Matthew's Greek is much more stylistic and clean).
- If Matthew was in fact an eyewitness, would he have used 80% of Mark's Greek account?

The Gospel of Matthew is quoted by some of our earliest 2nd-century Christian texts that post-date any New Testament work.

- The *Didache* (ch. 8, 10:5, or ch. 16) quotes Gospel sayings of Jesus in their uniquely Matthean form.
- Ignatius of Antioch (died 108 C.E.) quotes sayings of Jesus in their Matthean form (*Letter to the Smyrneans* 1.1 = Matt 3:15; *Letter to the Philadelphians* 3:1 = Matt. 15:13).

Internal Evidence About the Origins of the Gospel of Matthew

If Matthew adopts Mark as a primary source, and if Mark was written just prior to or after the destruction of the temple in 70 C.E., then this could provide a range of 70s-80s C.E.

The disciple Matthew is uniquely highlighted in this gospel. In Matthew chapter 9, Mark's account of the calling of "Levi" has been changed to "Matthew" in order to connect this Matthew with the Matthew in the list of the twelve disciples in Matthew 10:2 (adopted Mark 3:18).

Mark 2:14 NASB

As he passed by, he saw **Levi the son of Alphaeus** sitting in the tax booth, and he said to him, "Follow me!" And he got up and followed him.

Matthew 9:9 LEB

And as Jesus was going away from there, he saw a man called **Matthew** sitting at the tax booth and said to him, "Follow me!" And he stood up and followed him.

Mark 3:16-18 NASB

¹⁶ And he appointed the twelve: Simon (to whom he gave the name Peter), ¹⁷ and James, the son of Zebedee, and John the brother of James (to them he gave the name Boanerges, which means "Sons of Thunder"); ¹⁸ and Andrew, and Philip, and Bartholomew, and **Matthew**, and Thomas, and James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus, and Simon the Zealot;

Matthew 10:2-3 LEB

² Now these are the names of the twelve apostles: first Simon who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother, James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother, ³ Philip, and Bartholomew, Thomas, and **Matthew the tax collector**, James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus,

This curious change has been explained in a number of different ways.

1. Matthew knew, independently of Mark's source tradition, that man's name was Mattathias. It's possible that he knew this because (1a) the Gospel's author was in fact this very Mattathias, or (1b) because he knew this man by two names, Levi and Mattathias. It was not uncommon for Jewish men to go by two names, one more traditional (Levi) and the other more contemporary (Mattathias is a Greek pronunciation of the Hebrew *Mattityah* = "Gift of Yahweh"). See also Saul/Paul, or Simon/Peter.
2. Matthew observed that no one named Levi was among the twelve disciples (listed in [Matt. 10:2-4](#)), while there was indeed a Mattathias (see [Matt. 10:3](#)). He reasoned that because this Mattathias has a narrative dedicated to his being called by Jesus, just as Simon, Andrew, James, and John do (see [Matt. 4:18-22](#)), that Levi was also named Matthew. Note also that Mark names Levi as a "son of Alphaeus," who was likely a brother of "James son of Alphaeus," one of the twelve (see [Mark 3:16-19](#)). It is possible that Levi/Matthew was the brother of James, so that half of Jesus' twelve disciples were actually brothers: Simon/Peter and Andrew, James and John, James and Levi/Matthew.

Matthew clearly assumes his audience is an observant Jewish one that cares very much about true observance of the commands in the Torah.

- The Torah case studies in [ch. 5](#)
- The disputes over true Sabbath observance in [12:1-7](#) and [12:8-21](#)
- The critique of the Pharisees' interpretation of Torah in [5:20](#) and [23:23](#)

Matthew also clearly reflects a conviction that Jesus' focus on Israel was for a time and that after the resurrection, the Kingdom of God is fully inclusive of non-Israelites. Inclusion of the nations is a significant theme in Matthew.

- The diverse crowds in [4:25](#)
- The Roman centurion in [8:5-13](#)
- The [Isaiah 42](#) quote in [12:17-21](#)
- The Canaanite woman in [15:21-28](#)
- The great commission to baptize and teach the nations in [28:18-20](#) (Notice he doesn't say "and circumcise the nations," which shows the influence of the apostolic decree in [Acts 15](#) and an alignment with Paul's gentile mission.)

Matthew reflects bitter hostility toward the city of Jerusalem and the Pharisees as illegitimate leaders of Israel (see [Matt. 23](#)). This hostility likely comes from the growing tension during the late 1st century between Jewish followers of Jesus and Jewish leaders who aren't open to the mission to the Gentiles.

Matthew uniquely highlights the region of "Syria" as coming under the influence of Jesus' mission.

- "Nazarene" (from [Matt. 2:23](#)) was and still is a Syrian term for "Christian."
- Syria is uniquely mentioned by Matthew as among the places from which people came to hear and see Jesus ([Matt. 4:24](#)).
- The woman who is called "Syrian-Phonecian" in [Mark 7:26](#) is called the "Canaanite" woman in [Matt. 15:22](#), the term that Phonecians used to describe themselves in their own Semitic language.
- We know from [Acts 10-15](#) that Antioch was a prominent multicultural hub for the Jesus movement in the years 50-80 C.E., in a network of churches that began out of messianic Jewish synagogues. This is a

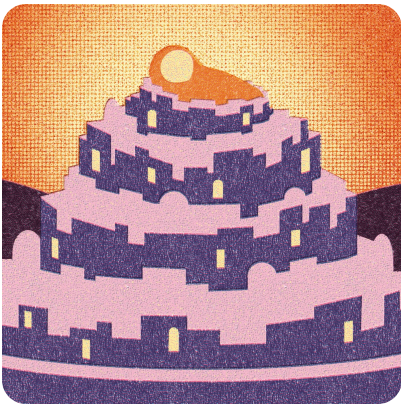
plausible setting for the production of such a work.

The Gospel of Matthew is the product of an extremely learned community of scholars who were multilingual (Greek, Latin, Hebrew, and Aramaic) and who were deeply immersed in Israel's Scriptures. It's not beyond imagination that the disciple Matthew was an aged and revered figure in such a community (we know Peter ended up there, see [Gal. 2:11-14](#)).

In the notes that follow, I will use the name "Matthew" to refer to the messianic Jewish scholar who produced this amazing work, along with the broader Christian community and scribal network in which he worshipped, studied, and wrote. Whether or not it was the Apostle Matthew, the account stems from the eyewitness testimony of the apostles (through Mark and the teaching traditions that Matthew received), and the work was accepted as apostolic by the earliest generations of Jesus' followers.

Reflection Question

Do we know who wrote Matthew's Gospel? What internal and external evidence do we have about the authorship of Matthew? How important are these questions to you?



Module 2: The Birth of the Messiah

SESSIONS 5-10

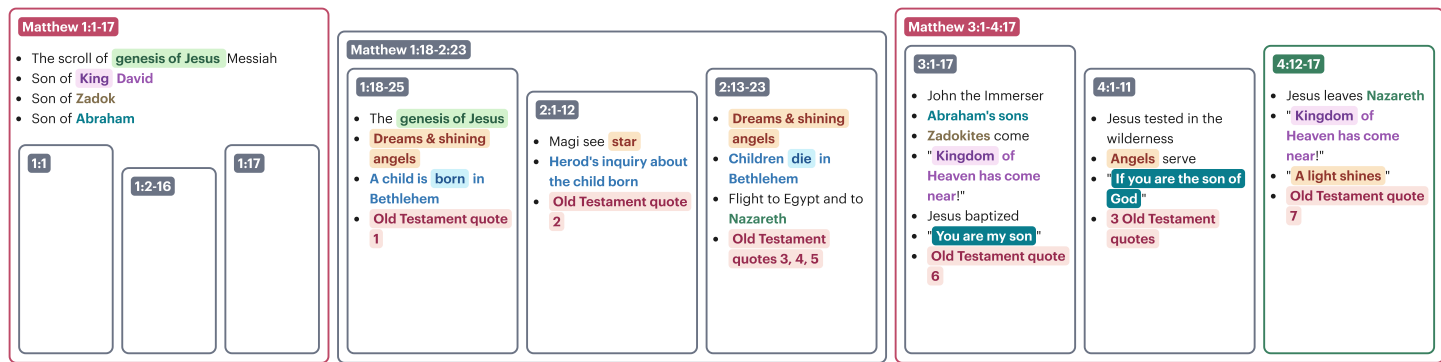
Explore the genealogy and birth of Jesus in Matthew 1-2. Learn key themes, historical context, and theological significance in the birth of the Messiah.

Session 5: A Messianic Genealogy

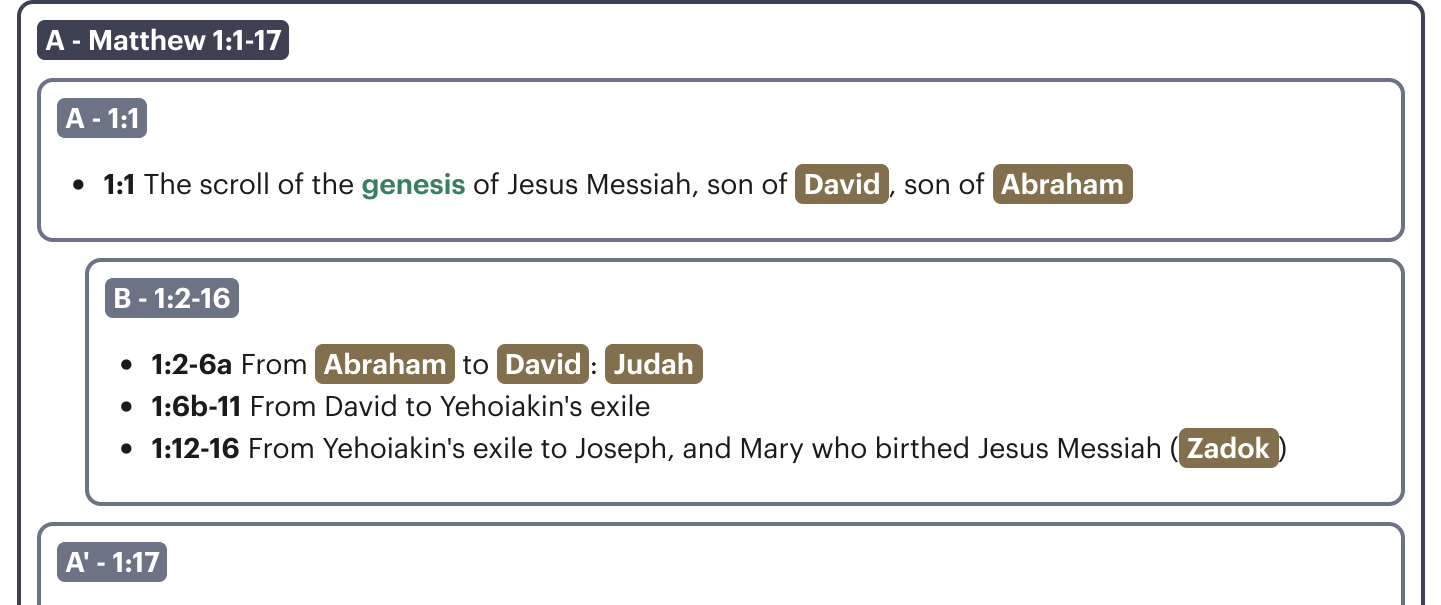
Key Takeaways

- Matthew shapes Jesus’ genealogy to focus on Jesus as the Son of David, Son of Abraham, and promised Messiah.
- Biblical authors employ numbers as vehicles of meaning. Matthew highlights numerical wordplays in this genealogy, inviting readers to contemplate deeper layers of meaning.
- The focus on “brothers” in the first two sections of the genealogy invites readers to look for the missing brothers in the third section.
- Matthew’s inclusion of five women in the genealogy links Jesus’ story to a pattern of God using surprising people and means to fulfill his promises.

Matthew 1:1-4:17 — Design and Message



Matthew 1:1-4:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).



- **1:17** 3 sets of 14 generations from **Abraham** to **David** to the exile to the Messiah

B - Matthew 1:18-2:23

A - 1:18-25

"The genesis of Jesus Messiah was like this ..."

- a - **1:18-23** Mary **pregnant** by Holy Spirit, **angel "appears" (phaino)** to Joseph, "**take Mary**"
- b - **1:22-23** **Old Testament quote 1 (Isa. 7:14)**
- a' - **1:24-25** Joseph obeys **angelic dream**, **takes Mary**, who **births a son**: Jesus

B - 2:1-12

- a - **2:1-3** Jesus was **born** in **Bethlehem**, magi see **star** in the east and come to **worship**, Herod hears
- b - **2:4-6** Herod's inquiry to Messiah's **birth** town: **Old Testament quote 2 (Mic. 5:4)**
- a' - **2:7-12** Herod & magi, trip to **Bethlehem**, **star** leads to child, **worship**, magi **dream** & depart

A' - 2:13-23

- a - **2:13-15** Joseph's **angelic dream**, "take child and Mary to Egypt" + **Old Testament quote 3 (Hos. 11:1)**
- b - **2:16-18** Herod **murders the sons** of Bethlehem + **Old Testament quote 4 (Jer. 31:17)**
- a' - **2:19-23** Joseph's **angelic dream**, "take child and Mary back to Israel" + **Old Testament quote 5 (Isa 11:1)**

A' - Matthew 3:1-4:17

A - 3:1-17

- a - **3:1-6** John the Baptizer, **Old Testament quote 6 (Isa. 40)**, Jerus. & **Judea** come, "**Repent, Kingdom of God has arrived!**"
- b - **3:7-12** **Zadokites** come, John's speech: Who are **Abraham's** children? Baptism of Spirit & fire
- a' - **3:13-17** Baptism of Jesus: voice from the skies, Spirit descends, "You are my **Son**"

B - 4:1-11

- **4:1** Jesus in the wilderness, tested by slanderer for 40 days
- **4:2-10** 3 tests of Jesus' loyalty, **3 Old Testament quotes (Deut. 8:6; 6:13; 16)**
- **4:11** Slanderer leaves Jesus, **angels** come and serve

- **4:12-17** Jesus goes to Nazareth, "repent, Kingdom of God has arrives" + Old Testament quote 7 (Isa. 9:1), light "shining"

Matthew 1:1-4:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Matthew 1:1-17 — A Messianic Genealogy

1:1 The scroll of the birth-beginning (γενεσις) of Iesous Messiah, son of Daudid, son of Abra'am:

2 Abra'am¹ birthed (γεννω) Isaak,
and Isaak² birthed Iakob,
and Iakob³ birthed Iouda and his brothers,
3 and Iouda⁴ birthed Phares and Zara from Tamar,
and Phares⁵ birthed Esrom,
and Esrom⁶ birthed Aram,
4 and Aram⁷ birthed Aminadab,
and Aminadab⁸ birthed Nasson,
and Nasson⁹ birthed Salmon,
5 and Salmon¹⁰ birthed Boes from Rakhab,
and Boes¹¹ birthed Iobed from Ruth,
and Iobed¹² birthed Iessai,
6 and Iessai¹³ birthed Daudid 14, the king,
and Daudid¹⁴ birthed Solomon from the one of Ouriah,

7 and Solomon¹⁵ birthed Roboam,
and Roboam¹⁶ birthed Abia,
and Abia¹⁷ birthed Asaph,
8 and Asaph¹⁸ birthed Iosaphat,
and Iosaphat¹⁹ birthed Ioram,
and Ioram²⁰ birthed Ozia,
9 and Ozia²¹ birthed Iotham,
and Iotham²² birthed Akhaz,
and Akhaz²³ birthed Ezekia,
10 and Ezekia²⁴ birthed Manasse,
and Manasse²⁵ birthed Amos,
and Amos²⁶ birthed Iosiah,

¹¹ and Iosia²⁷ **birthed** Iekhoniah²⁸ **and his brothers**,
until **the exile of Babylon**.

¹² After **the exile of Babylon**,
Iekhoniah²⁸ **birthed** Salathiel,
and Salathiel²⁹ **birthed** Zorobabel,
¹³ and Zorobabel³⁰ **birthed** Abioud,
and Abioud³¹ **birthed** Eliakim,
and Eliakim³² **birthed** Azor,
¹⁴ and Azor³³ **birthed** Sadok,
and Sadok³⁴ **birthed** Akhim,
and Akhim³⁵ **birthed** Elioud,
¹⁵ and Elioud³⁶ **birthed** Eleazar,
and Eleazar³⁷ **birthed** Matthan,
and Matthan³⁸ **birthed** Iakob,
¹⁶ and Iakob³⁹ **birthed** Ioseph⁴⁰, the husband of **Maria**,
from whom was **birthed** **Iesous**⁴¹,
who is called "Messiah."

¹⁷ All the **birth-generations (γενεα)** from **Abra'am** until **Dauid**: fourteen **birth-generations**,
and from Dauid until **the exile of Babylon**: fourteen **birth-generations**,
and from **the exile of Babylon** until **the Messiah**: fourteen **birth-generations**.

Matthew 1:1-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

The Genesis of Iesous

Matthew has introduced Jesus with a TaNaK-style genealogy (see [1 Chron. 1-9](#)), showing how his birth fulfills the long story of God's relationship with Israel. The three-part scheme (Abraham, David, exile to Babylon) shows how Matthew understands Israel's history as portrayed in the Hebrew Bible.

"The genealogy ensures continuity between Israel's story and the story that Matthew is about to narrate ... This genealogy prepares the reader to interpret Jesus as the heir of the promises to Abraham, the consummation of Israel's epic story that began in the patriarchal narratives of Genesis ... The strong emphasis given to Israel's exile imparts a particular shape to the history: the story of Israel is a story that juxtaposes God's covenant faithfulness—signified by the promise to Abraham and the promise to David of an everlasting kingdom—with Israel's unfaithfulness, as signified ... by the checkered history of the kings that led up to the deportation to Babylon ... The Messiah, in Matthew's narrative, is the one who saves his people from the consequences of their sins by closing the chapter of powerlessness and deprivation that began with the exile to Babylon ... Jesus is the one who will bring about the end of Israel's exile."

Hays, Richard B. (2017). [Echoes of Scripture in the Gospels](#). Baylor University Press. 110-111.

The opening line of the genealogy makes three implicit claims about the identity of Jesus: He is a new Adam, a new Abraham, and a new David.

The scroll of the birth-beginning (βιβλος γενεσεως) of Iesous Messiah	Genesis 5:1: “This is the scroll of the birthings (ספר תולדת) / βιβλος γενεσεως) of Adam ”
son of David	2 Samuel 7: David , father of the messianic seed for Israel
son of Abra’am	Genesis 12:1-3, 22:18: Abraham , father of the seed for the blessing of the nations
<i>The Opening Genealogical Line.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

Jesus and Adam: By modeling the opening words of his genealogy after the genealogy of Adam in [Genesis 5:1](#), Matthew makes a key analogy between Jesus and Adam that functions as a foundation for the entire story. Jesus is the new human who will address the folly and failure of Adam and Eve and who will confront the snake who deceived them, reversing death. This all remains implicit, but we know that the apostles elsewhere saw a connection between Adam and Jesus (see [Rom. 5:12-21](#)).

Jesus and Abraham: By linking Jesus to the seed of Abraham, Matthew marks Jesus as the one through whom God’s blessing will spread to all nations (see [Gen. 12:1-3](#) and [Gen. 22:17-18](#)).

Jesus and David: By highlighting Jesus as the Son of David, Matthew makes an explicit claim that Jesus is the heir of God’s royal promises to David and his seed (see [2 Sam. 7](#) and [Ps. 72](#)), specifically that God’s Kingdom would spread to all nations through his line.

The Women in Jesus’ Genealogy

The fact that Matthew has given us a patriarchal (i.e., male) lineage of the royal line of David through Abraham and Judah highlights the presence of four women in the genealogy. And, additionally, the four women named are not the ones we would expect, like the matriarchs of Israel in Genesis: Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel, and Leah. The inclusion of these specific four women is part of a deliberate strategy because these four women are deeply connected within the narrative strategy of the Hebrew Bible.

- [Matthew 1:3](#): Tamar from [Genesis 38](#)
- [Matthew 1:5](#): Rahab from [Joshua 2](#)
- [Matthew 1:5](#): Ruth from [Ruth 1-4](#)
- [Matthew 1:6](#): Wife of Uriah (= Bathsheba) from [2 Samuel 11-12](#) and [1 Kings 1-2](#)

The following table shows how all four women’s stories have been designed with many important hyperlinks that set each on analogy with the others.

	Tamar Genesis 38	Rahab Joshua 2, 6	Ruth Ruth 1-4	Bathsheba 2 Sam 11-12 & 1 Kgs 1-2	The Canaanite Woman Matthew 15:21-28
A non-Israelite, on the “kick them out” lists in Deut. 7:1; 20:1	Gen. 38:6, 11 Judah’s wife is Canaanite; Tamar’s father lives nearby	Josh. 2:1 Rahab is a Canaanite prostitute who lives in Jericho	Ruth 1:4 Mahlon and Kilion “took for themselves Moabite wives”	2 Sam. 11:3 “Isn’t this Bathsheba, daughter of Eliam, wife of Uriah the Hittite?”	Matt. 15:21-22 “Jesus went into the region of Tyre and Sidon, and behold, a Canaanite woman from those regions came out ...”
Recently widowed	Gen. 38:8-10 Tamar becomes twice widowed		Ruth 1:5 Ruth becomes a widow	2 Sam. 11 Bathsheba becomes widowed because David murders her husband	
Unusual “liaison” with the promised lineage	Gen. 38:12-19 Tamar disguises as a prostitute to maintain the family “seed”	Josh. 2:1b-7 They “go into” Rahab the prostitute’s house at night	Ruth 3:2-14 Ruth secretly meets Boaz at night in the threshing floor	2 Sam. 11:1-4 David’s affair takes place at night, while he stays home during a war	
Bold assertion toward the line of David/Joshua	Gen. 38:25-26 Tamar proves Judah’s guilt with cord and seal	Josh. 2:12 “Now, swear to me by Yahweh, since I have done <i>khesed</i> to you, that you do <i>khesed</i> to my father’s house”	Ruth 3:9 “I am Ruth your servant. So spread your covering over your servant, for you are a kinsman-redeemer.”	1 Kgs. 1:15-21 Bathsheba requests that Solomon be made king instead of Adonijah	Matt. 15:25-27 Jesus’ silence prompts her to say “Lord! Help me!” She counters Jesus’ parable with a tweaked

Women Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

	Tamar Genesis 38	Rahab Joshua 2, 6	Ruth Ruth 1-4	Bathsheba 2 Sam 11-12 & 1 Kgs 1-2	The Canaanite Woman Matthew 15:21-28
					parable in return
Red cord = Symbol of deliverance	Gen. 38:18, 25 "cord" belongs to Judah Gen. 38:28 "red" tied to firstborn	Josh. 2:18-19 a "red cord" is tied to the window "as a sign of faith " (אמת)			Matt. 15:28 "Great is your faith , O woman! Let it be as you desire."
Confession of faith in God of Israel OR Request for mercy/favor		Josh. 2:10-11 "Yahweh your God, he is God in heaven above and earth below"	Ruth 1:16 "Your people will be my people, and your God, my God"		Matt. 15:22b She cried out, "Lord, Son of David, have mercy on me!"
Sets precedent for Gentile inclusion		Josh. 9 The Gibeonites			Matt. 15:29-38 The feeding of the 4,000 Gentiles follows

Women Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

"Jesus' identification in Matthew 1 as the 'Son of David,' is capable of many meanings, but the presence of these gentile women highlights the inclusiveness of the Messiah's role, to be a blessing to the nations as well as to save his own people from their sins ... Is the Davidic Messiah's role to be that of a new Joshua, who will again lead an obedient Israel to drive out the Canaanites? ... Or do the Canaanite women in Jesus' ancestry require a more positive relationship to gentiles? All this is at stake in Jesus' encounter with the Canaanite woman in Matthew 15:21-28. She may as well have stepped out of the genealogy, in order to press her own claims on the line of David as Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and Bathsheba each did in their own way."

Bauckham, Richard (2002). "The Gentile Forerunners of the Messiah." [*Gospel Women: Studies of the Named Women in the Gospels*](#). Eerdmans. 44.

The Numerical Patterns in Matthew’s Genealogy

Matthew structures the genealogy into three sets of 14 generations, which creatively reshapes the traditional accounts of the lineage of David that we know from 1 Chronicles, which was certainly Matthew’s source.

In order to achieve the number 3 x 14, Matthew had to omit multiple generations from David’s genalogy.

Matthew 1:8-9	1 Chronicles 3:10-12
... Yehoshaphat Yoram - - - - - - - - - Uzziyahu Yotam ...	... Yehoshaphat Yoram Ahaziah Yoash Amaziah Azariah (= Uzziyahu) Yotam
Numerical Patterns in Matthew’s Genealogy—David. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

In the second list Matthew mentions “Ieknoniah and his brothers.” He omits three kings who ruled in short succession in the final generation of the exile before Ieknoniah.

Matthew 1:11	1 Chronicles 3:15-17
Iosia - - - - - - - - - Iekhonia	Josiah Jehoiakim Zedekiah Shallum (= Jehoahaz) Jeconiah
Numerical Patterns in Matthew’s Genealogy—Kings. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

Matthew also omits multiple generations in the third list, betwen Zerubbabel and Joseph and Mary. 1 Chronicles 3:19-24 provides a list of the six (or perhaps five) sons of Zerubbabel, but none of them match the names that Matthew lists here. The period in between Zerubbabel and Joseph is nearly 500 years, and Matthew has provides 13 names. The second list covers nearly 400 years, and Matthew provides 14 names, and we know he omitted many more. We assume that Matthew has also omitted names from this third list as well.

Numerical Symbolism (a.k.a. “Gematria”)

Biblical authors often used the numerical value of Hebrew and Greek letters to create more subtle layers of meaning that connect with the larger themes of the book. Steven Bryan has provided a thorough analysis of Matthew’s compositional technique and proposes that the names found at all four key junctures in the genealogy are numerically significant (information and chart adapted from Steven Bryan, “Onomastics and Numerical Composition in the Genealogy of Matthew,” *Bulletin for Biblical Research* vol. 30 [2020], 515-39).

Value of Name	Position in Genealogy
41	1st — Abraham
14	14th — David
40	28th — Jeconiah
	41st — Jesus
42	42nd — Messiah

Numerical Genealogy. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

1. Abraham: Jesus is placed in 41st position in the genealogy, precisely the numerical value of “Abraham” in Hebrew (אַבְרָהָם = 41).
2. David: The 3 x 14 shape of the genealogy is a numerical wordplay on the name “David” in Hebrew (דָּוִד = 14).
3. Christ: “Christos” / “Messiah” is placed as the 42nd name, precisely the numerical value of the Hebrew word “Messiah” (מָשִׁיחַ = 42).
4. Jeconiah, the last Davidic king before the exile to Babylon, has the numerical value of 40, precisely the number of names that leads up to Jesus, the 41st name (יְכִנְיָהוּ = 40).

For an Old Testament example of gematria in a genealogy, see the genealogy of the tribes of Jacob in [Genesis 46:8-27](#). 70 family members go with Jacob to Egypt; 14 children to Jacob through Rachel’s sons, 7 children through Bilhah’s line, Gad is the 7th in the list, who fathers 7 children; Gad = 7 in Hebrew (גָּד).

A Numerical Puzzle — 14 + 14 + 14 = 41??

One puzzle in Matthew’s genealogy is that he tells us in [1:17](#) that he has traced 3 x 14 generations from Abraham to the birth of the Messiah, and we know that he omitted multiple generations to come up with that number.

Why does he say “14 generations from the exile to the Messiah,” when he has only included 13 names?

Steven Bryan has offered a compelling solution (“The Missing Generation: The Completion of Matthew’s Genealogy,” in *Bulletin for Biblical Research* vol. 29, 294-316).

- Matthew has intentionally omitted many kings from the list.

- Matthew includes the unique phrase “and his brothers” two times in the genealogy.
 - “Judah and his brothers” (1:2)—Judah with his brothers make up the 12 brothers who go one to become the 12 tribes. This generation signals the constitution of the nation of Israel.
 - “Jechoniah and his brothers” (1:11)—Jechoniah and his brothers lived during the downfall of Judah and signalled the dissolution of the nation of Israel.

The fact that Matthew draws attention to the birth generation of Israel and then also to the exile-death generation of the nation means there can be little coincidence that Matthew leaves the third table of the genealogy unfinished, with one generation to go. Is it possible that the “Messiah and his brothers” will make up the 14th generation, completing the “David” number symbolism?

Matthew answers this question by leaving a trail of bread crumbs through the book. Notice how often Jesus describes his disciple community as a reconstituted Israel, picking up the royal heritage of their people.

Matthew 10:1-7 Instructor's Translation

¹ And summoning **his twelve apprentices** ...

² Now, the names of **the twelve apostles** are these:

first, Simon, the one called Petros

and Andreas **his brother**,

and Iakobos the one of Zebedaios,

and Ioannes **his brother** ...

⁵ These the twelve Jesus sent,

having instructed them, saying,

“Onto the road of the nations you will not depart,

and into a city of the Samaritans you will not enter,

⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel**,

⁷ and as you go, announce, saying,

"The kingdom of the skies has come near!"

Matthew 12:46-50 Instructor's Translation

⁴⁶ While he was still speaking to the crowds,

look, his mother and brothers had been standing outside,
seeking to speak with him,

⁴⁷ and someone said to him,

“Look, your mother and your brothers have been standing outside,
seeking to speak with you.”

⁴⁸ And responding he said to the one speaking to him,

“Who is my mother?

And who are my brothers?”

⁴⁹ And extending his hand to his apprentices, he said,

“Look, my mother and my brothers.

⁵⁰ For **whoever does the desire of my father in the skies,**
that one is my brother and sister and mother.”

Matthew 19:28 Instructor's Translation

And Iesous said to them,
"Amen, I say to y'all,
that y'all who follow me,
in the re-birthing,
when the son of the human sits upon the throne of his honor,
y'all too will sit upon twelve thrones,
judging the twelve tribes of Israel;

Matthew 28:9-10 Instructor's Translation

⁹ And look, Iesous met them, saying,
"Good day!"
And approaching, they grabbed his feet and bowed down to him.
¹⁰ Then Iesous said to them,
"Don't be afraid."
Go announce to my brothers
that they should depart unto Galilaias,
and there they will see me."

The Genealogies of Matthew and Luke

The Enoch Dimension and the Number 7 in Luke’s Genealogy

- There are 77 generations (11 sets of 7) between Adam and Jesus in [Luke 3:23-38](#), which is a number of “ultimate fulfillment” (remember Lemek’s 77 in [Gen. 4:24](#) and Jesus’ ironic allusion to this story and number in [Matt. 18:22](#)).
- Enoch is in the 7th position (as he is in [Gen. 5:21](#)).
- The only ancestor of Jesus (= Yeshua) to share his name is in the 49th position, and Jesus himself is in the 77th position.
- Abraham culminates the third set of 7 generations, and David culminates the fifth set of 7 generations.
- There are 49 (= 7 x 7) generations between Adam and Jesus (Ιησους, [Matt. 3:29](#)), the only ancestor to share Jesus of Nazareth’s name. The number 49 echoes the ten Jubilee cycles from [Daniel 9](#) (7 x 70).

Luke has designed the genealogy so that the first four rounds of seven generations conclude with a key patriarch.

1st Seven	Enoch
2nd Seven	Shelah
Enoch Dimension. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

3rd Seven	Abraham
4th Seven	Admin
5th Seven	David
6th Seven	Joseph
7th Seven	Jesus (= Yehoshua)
8th Seven	Shealtiel
9th Seven	Mattathias
10 Seven	Joseph
11th Seven = 77th generation = Jesus of Nazareth	
<i>Enoch Dimension. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>	

“Luke’s genealogy embodies a claim about Jesus’ identity. It gives Jesus the place of ultimate significance in world history. It includes and highlights his descent from David by the non-royal line as the prophesied messianic son. However, he is more than just a a new David. David has his own special place as the fifth 'seventh,' as does Abraham as the third 'seventh,' but Jesus’ position at the end of the eleventh seven, in the seventy-seventh generation surpasses that of every predecessor from Adam onwards. He is greater than Enoch and greater than Abraham and David. He is the consummation of human history.”

Bauckham, Richard (2015). “The Lukan Genealogy of Jesus,” in [Jude and the Relatives of Jesus in the Early Church](#). Bloomsbury Academic. 365.

Luke and Matthew Compared

Luke’s Genealogy	Matthew’s Genealogy
Adam to Abraham	----
Abraham to David	Abraham to David
<i>Comparing Luke and Matthew. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>	

Luke's Genealogy	Matthew's Genealogy
David Nathan Mattatha Menna Melea Eliakim Yonam Yoseph Yudah Simeon Levi Matthat Yorim Eliezer Yeshua Er Elmadam Cosam Addi Melchi Neri Shealtiel Zerubbabel	David Solomon Rehoboam Abiyah Asa Yehoshaphat Yoram [Ahaziah, omitted, see 1 Chron. 3:11] [Yoash, omitted, see 1 Chron. 3:11] [Amaziyah, omitted, see 1 Chron 3:12] Uzziyah Yotham Akhaz Khizkiyah Manasshe Amon Yoshiah Yekonyah Shealtiel Zerubbabel
Rhesa Yoanan Yoda Yosekh Semein Mattathias Maath Naggai Hesli Nahum Amos Mattathias Ioseph Yannai Melchi Levi Matthat Eli	Abioud Eliakim Azor Sadok Achim Elioud Eleazar Matthan Iakob Yoseph Yeshua!!
<i>Comparing Luke and Matthew.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

Yoseph
Yeshua!!

Yoseph
Yeshua!!

Yoseph
Yeshua!!

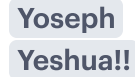
Yoseph
Yeshua!!

- Yoseph
Yeshua!!

Yoseph
Yeshua!!

Yoseph
Yeshua!!

Yoseph
Yeshua!!



Yoseph
Yeshua!!

Yoseph
Yeshua!!

genealogy, but through David's little-known ninth son Nathan. While making contact with the official line of heirs to the Davidic throne in Zerubbabel and his father Shealtiel, the genealogy otherwise consists of entirely unknown names between Nathan and Joseph. This embodies an interpretation of the prophecies of the Davidic messiah, according to which the Messiah is to come not from the line of David's royal successors but from David's own family origins in Bethlehem (see Isaiah 11:1-5 and Micah 5:1-2) ... The new king is not to be born in the royal palace in Jerusalem, but in insignificant Bethlehem, where David's own story began ... among the ordinary people. Bethlehem is the city of David, but not of any of David's sons through Solomon."

Bauckham, Richard (2002). "The Gentile Forerunners of the Messiah." [*Gospel Women: Studies of the Named Women in the Gospels*](#). Eerdmans. 73-74.

Reflection Question

What major features of Matthew's genealogy did you notice? How do these features communicate meaning as an introduction to Matthew's Gospel?

Session 6: The Birth of Jesus

Key Takeaways

- Matthew highlights Joseph's righteousness, establishing an important pattern of characters who answer the call to do right by God.
- The Spirit miraculously brings about Jesus' conception within Mary's womb, echoing the biblical pattern of the Spirit of God bringing new life in unexpected places.
- Jesus' name means "Yahweh will rescue," and his name connects to the hoped for messiah who will restore Israel's kingdom and to Greek and Roman ideas about the good news of a king who is savior of the world.

Matthew 1:18-2:23 — The Birth of the Messiah

Matthew 1:18-25

A - Jesus Is Conceived

- a - 1:18-21 Mary **pregnant** by Holy Spirit, **angel "appears" (phaino)** to Joseph, "**take Mary**"
- b - 1:22-23 **Old Testament quote 1 (Isa. 7:14)**
- a' - 1:24-25 Joseph obeys **angelic dream**, **takes Mary**, who **births a son**: Jesus

Matthew 2:1-12

B - Jesus Is Born

- a - 2:1-3 Jesus was **born** in **Bethlehem**, magi see **star** in the east and come to **worship**, Herod hears
- b - 2:4-6 Herod's inquiry to Messiah's **birth** town: **Old Testament quote 2 (Mic. 5:4)**
- a' - 2:7-12 **Star "appears" (phaino)**, leads Magi to child, **worship**, magi **dream** & depart

Matthew 2:13-23

A' - Jesus' Exile & Return

- a - 2:13-15 Joseph's **angelic dream**, "take child and Mary to Egypt" + **Old Testament quote 3 (Hos. 11:1)**
- b - 2:16-18 Herod **murders the sons** of Bethlehem + **Old Testament quote 4 (Jer. 31:17)**
- a' - 2:19-23 Joseph's **angelic dream**, "take child and Mary back to Israel" + **Old Testament quote 5 (Isa 11:1)**

Matthew has pulled together five episodes in the story of infant Jesus and organized them into three bundles.

1. Unit 1 (Matthew 1:18-25)
 - Episode 1: Mary's pregnancy, Joseph's marriage to Mary, the birth of Jesus
2. Unit 2 (Matthew 2:1-12)
 - Episode 2: The visit of the magi from the East
3. Unit 3 (Matthew 2:13-23)
 - Episode 3: Joseph takes Mary and Jesus, leaves Israel, and goes to Egypt
 - Episode 4: Herod's massacre of Israelite boys in Bethlehem
 - Episode 5: Joseph takes Mary and Jesus, leaves Egypt, and goes to Israel and Nazareth

By organizing the stories in this way, Matthew has shaped each of the three units in a symmetrical design, inviting the reader to notice hyperlinks and narrative analogies.

Stars and angels: The presence of guiding angels and dreams in A (1:18-25) and A' (2:13-23) allows the reader to see the dream and shining star of the magi story in B (2:1-12) as parallel. Specifically, Matthew uses the same word "shine/appear" (φαίνω, 1:23/2:13) to describe the angel and the star, leading readers to conclude that the star guiding the magi is, in fact, an angel.

Hebrew Bible quotes: Notice how the Hebrew Bible quotes in units 1 and 2 occupy the central panels of the story, while in unit 3, a quotation occurs in all three panels of the story, giving it a climactic role in the sequence of stories.

The death and life of sons: Notice how the birth of Jesus in unit 1 is contrasted with the murder of the sons in unit 3.

Joseph "takes" Mary: In unit 1, the angels direct Joseph to "take" (παραλαμβάνω) Mary in marriage (Matt. 1:20) to protect her reputation. In unit 3, the angel again directs Joseph to "take" (παραλαμβάνω) Mary (Matt. 2:13, 19) to and from Egypt, again to protect her, but this time also to save her baby's life.

Matthew 1:18-25

¹⁸ Now, the **birth-beginning** (γενεσις) of **Jesus Messiah** was this way:

- A
- a His mother, **Maria**,
 - b having been **engaged** to **Joseph**,
 - b' **before they had come together**,
 - a' she was found to **have in the womb by the Holy Spirit**,

- a ¹⁹ and **Joseph her husband**,
- b being a righteous one,

R

b' and not desiring to make her a public spectacle,
a' **he** wanted to send **her** away privately.

20 And while he was thinking about these things,
look, **a messenger of the Lord** appeared to him in **a dream**, saying,

a' "Ioseph, **son of David**,
do not be afraid **to take Maria** as your **wife**,
A' b' because what has been **birthed inside her**
is from the Holy Spirit,

a' 21 and she will **birth** a **son**,
and **you will call his name Iesous**,
because he will **save** his people from their moral-failings."

a' 22 And all of this happened
so that what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet would be filled-full, saying,
b' 23 "Look, **the virgin** will **have in the womb** and will **birth** a **son**,
and **they will call his name Emmanuel**,
a' which is translated ' **With Us Is God** .'"

24 And, after **Ioseph** got up from **sleep**,
he did as **the messenger of the Lord** commanded him,
and **he took his wife**,
25 and **he did not know her** until she **birthed** a **son**,
and he called his name **Iesous**.

Matthew 1:18-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

This compact presentation of Mary's pregnancy and Joseph's response has been clearly organized in a three-part sequence.

A — Narrative (v. 18-21): Mary's pregnancy, angelic message to Joseph

B — Narrator's comment (v. 22-23): Fulfillment quotation

A' — Narrative (v. 24-25): Mary gives birth, Joseph's obedient response to angelic message

Joseph's Point of View

The opening birth story of Jesus is told entirely from Joseph's point of view, whereas Luke's account is told with an emphasis on Mary's experience. Matthew highlights many facets of Joseph's character, both explicitly and implicitly.

Explicit characterization of Joseph

- “Joseph was a righteous one” = He was Torah-observant, doing right by God and neighbor in all his ways.

Implicit characterization of Joseph

- “He didn’t want to make a public spectacle” of Mary = Joseph knew the social consequences for Mary if he were to make public the news of her teenage pregnancy.
- “He had planned to divorce her quietly” = In 1st century Jewish culture, most marriages were arranged by the parents, and engagements were legally binding. They were viewed with the utmost seriousness and were virtually equivalent to being married.

“As elsewhere in the Mediterranean world, fathers were guardians of their daughters’ virginity, arranged their marriages, and ‘gave’ them to their husbands. Witnesses and a symbolic act were essential for ‘erusin’, or Jewish betrothal; although Romans sometimes used ‘engagement rings,’ Judaism seems to have adopted this custom only later. Betrothal’s function was primarily commercial, but it was quite serious legally: dissolved only through divorce if both partners lived, betrothal similarly left the survivor of the man’s death a widow. Although a betrothed couple like Joseph and Mary did not live together or have intercourse, their union was as binding as marriage.”

Keener, Craig S. (2009). [*The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*](#). Eerdmans. 90-91.

Joseph and Genesis

Notice how Matthew has woven subtle hyperlinks to Genesis throughout this narrative.

- Joseph is given direction about marrying Mary while he is sleeping. // God provides a wife for Adam while he is sleeping ([Gen. 2:18-25](#)).
- Mary is pregnant by the power of God’s Spirit, a miraculous pregnancy. // God enabled the miraculous pregnancies of Sarah/Isaac, Rachel/Joseph ([Gen. 21, 30](#)).
- When Joseph finds out Mary is pregnant, he suspects sexual promiscuity, though he wants to compassionately end the engagement. // Judah finds out that Tamar is pregnant and suspects sexual promiscuity, and he wants to mercilessly end her life ([Gen. 38:24-26](#)).

Life by the Spirit

The role of the Holy Spirit in Jesus’ conception is highlighted two times ([Matt. 1:18, 20](#)), and forms an important inclusio frame around all of [Matthew chapters 1-4](#), where the Spirit again plays a key role in the story of Jesus’ baptism by John ([3:11, 16; 4:1](#)). In the Hebrew Bible, the Spirit is associated with the creation of life.

Genesis 1:2 Instructor's Translation

Now the land was wild and waste,
and darkness was over the surface of the deep,
and **the Spirit of Elohim** was fluttering over the waters.

Genesis 2:4b-7 Instructor's Translation

^{4b} In the day when Yahweh Elohim made the land and skies,
⁵ and no shrub of the field was yet in the land,
and no plant of the field had yet sprouted,
for Yahweh Elohim had not sent rain upon the land,
and there was no human to work the ground,
⁶ but **a stream would go up from the land**
and it would water the whole face of the ground,
⁷ then Yahweh Elohim formed the human of dust from the ground,
and **he breathed** into his nostrils the breath of life;
and **the human became a living being.**

Psalm 104:29-30 NASB

²⁹ You hide Your face [from animals],
they are dismayed;
you take away their **spirit** ,
they expire and return to their dust.
³⁰ You send forth your **Spirit** ,
they are **created**;
and you **renew** the face of the ground.

Isaiah 44:3-4 NASB

³ For **I will pour out water** on the thirsty land
and streams on the dry ground;
I will pour out my Spirit on your seed
and my blessing on your descendants;
⁴ And **they will spring up** among the grass
like poplars by streams of water.

In the creation narratives of Genesis, the presence of God's Spirit as life-generator is associated with God's control of the waters. Specifically, in the Eden narrative ([Gen. 2:4-3:24](#)), the generation of life from the wet dirt takes place when God breathes into the formed mud and gives life to the human.

After this, the arrival of God's Spirit is associated with the creation of life from non-life, and it is explored from many angles in biblical poetry. [Psalm 104](#) meditates on how life and death result from the gift or withdrawal of God's Spirit. [Isaiah 44](#) meditates on how the rebirth of Israel after Babylonian exile will only take place when God brings a "new Eden" blessing of water and Spirit.

The miraculous births in Genesis (Isaac in [Gen. 21](#), Jacob and Esau in [Gen. 25](#), Joseph in [Gen. 31](#)) are all set on analogy to these "spirit-birth" stories in Genesis. This explains why the Apostle Paul equates the conception of Isaac on analogy to creation and resurrection from the dead in [Romans 4](#).

Romans 4:16-21 NASB*

¹⁶ ... Abraham, who is the father of us all,
¹⁷ (as it is written,

“A father of many nations have I made you”)
in the presence of him whom he trusted, namely God,
who gives life to the dead
and calls into being that which does not exist.

¹⁸ In hope against hope he trusted,
that he might become a father of many nations
according to that which had been spoken,
“So shall your seed be.”

¹⁹ Without becoming weak in faith he contemplated his own body,
now as good as dead since he was about a hundred years old,
and the deadness of Sarah’s womb;

²⁰ yet, with respect to the promise of God,
he did not waver in lack-of-trust
but grew strong in trust, giving honor to God,

²¹ and being fully assured that what God had promised,
he was able also to do.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jesus = “Yahweh Will Rescue”

The meaning of Jesus’ name (Grk. Iesous / Heb. Yeshua) is “Yah will rescue” (long form: Yehoshua).

English: Jesus

Greek: Iesous / Ἰησοῦς

Hebrew (short form): Yeshua / ישוע

Hebrew (long form): Yehoshua / יהושוע

The idea of Yahweh “rescuing” Israel from their sins is a clear signal back to the message of the Hebrew prophets that the communal disasters that came upon Israel were a result of their violation of the terms of the covenant with Yahweh. In this context, “rescue from sin” refers to the oppression by foreign nations and scarcity in the land, described in detail in the covenant curses and blessings of the Torah (see [Lev. 26](#) and [Deut. 28](#)).

In the Hebrew prophets, rescue “from sin” means from the consequences of Israel’s sinful violations of the covenant with Yahweh. And conversely, “forgiveness” and “rescue” from sin means the ending of the period of covenant curse and the time of new Eden blessing for Israel for the nations.

Micah 7:15-20 NASB

¹⁵ “As in the days when you came out from the land of Egypt,
I will show you signs.”

¹⁶ Nations will see and be ashamed
of all their might.

They will put their hand on their mouth,
their ears will be deaf.

¹⁷ They will lick the dust like a serpent,
like reptiles of the earth.

They will come trembling out of their fortresses;
to the LORD our God they will come in dread
and they will be afraid before you.

¹⁸ Who is a God like you, who pardons iniquity
and passes over **the rebellious act of the remnant** of his possession?
He does not retain his anger forever,
because he delights in unchanging love.

¹⁹ He will again have compassion on us;
he will **tread our iniquities** under foot.
Yes, you will cast **all their sins**
into the depths of the sea.

²⁰ You will give truth to Jacob
and unchanging love to Abraham,
which you swore to our forefathers
from the days of old.

Jeremiah 31:31-34 LEB

³¹ Look, the days are coming," declares Yahweh, "and **I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel**
and with the house of Judah, ³² not like the covenant that I made with their ancestors on the day of my
grasping them by their hand, bringing them out from the land of Egypt, my covenant that they themselves
broke, though I myself was a master over them," declares Yahweh.

³³ "But this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares Yahweh: "I
will put my law in their inward parts and on their hearts I will write it, and I will be to them God, and they
themselves will be to me people.

³⁴ And they will no longer teach each one his neighbor, or each one his brother, saying, 'Know Yahweh,' for
all of them will know me, from their smallest and up to their greatest," declares Yahweh, "**for I will forgive
their iniquity and their sin I will no longer remember.**"

Jeremiah 50:18-20 LEB

¹⁸ Therefore thus says Yahweh of hosts, the God of Israel,
"Look, **I am going to punish the king of Babylon** and his land
just as I punished the king of Assyria.

¹⁹ And I will restore Israel to its pasture,
and it will feed on Carmel, and in Bashan,
and on the hills of Ephraim, and in Gilead
its hunger will be satisfied.

²⁰ In those days and at that time," declares Yahweh,
"the guilt of Israel will be sought, but there is none,

**and the sins of Judah, but they will not be found,
for I will forgive those I left behind.”**

Matthew consistently places before us moments where Jesus is the agent who releases God’s forgiveness to Israel.

“sin” = Greek *hamartia* / *αμαρτια* — “moral failing”

“release” = Greek *aphiemi* / *αφιημι* — “forgive, dismiss”

Matthew 9:2-6 Instructor's Translation

² and look, they brought to him a paralyzed-man,
laid up on a bed-mat,
and when Jesus saw their trust,
he said to the paralyzed-man,
“Have courage, child,

your moral-failings are released.”

³ And look, some of the scribes said among themselves,
“This man blasphemes.”

⁴ And when Jesus saw their thoughts, he said,
“Why are you thinking bad-things in your hearts?

⁵ What is easier, to say,
‘Your moral-failings are released’?
or to say,
‘Get up and walk’?

⁶ But in order that you can know that the son of the human has authority
on the land **to release moral-failings ...”**

Matthew 26:27-28 Instructor's Translation

²⁷ And after taking the cup and giving thanks, he gave to them, saying,
“Drink from it, all of you,

²⁸ for this is **my blood of the covenant**,
which is poured out **for the release of moral-failings ...”**

This last example from [Matthew 26](#) is crucial: Jesus views the sins he is addressing in his life, death, and resurrection as related to the covenant between God and Israel.

Son of David, Son of God

The role of the Holy Spirit in the conception and birth of Jesus is part of the narrative’s claim for Jesus’ divine identity as Son of God. The narrator makes very clear that Joseph is not to be understood as the biological father of Jesus.

However, given Joseph’s role in the genealogy of [Matthew 1:1-17](#), it is Joseph who is the descendant of David.

“In the Gospel of Matthew, it is not the son of David who is adopted by God as his son, but the reverse; it is the Son of God birthed by the Holy Spirit who is adopted into the family line of David through the action of Joseph.”

Konradt, Matthias (2020). [The Gospel according to Matthew: A Commentary](#). Baylor University Press. 35.

Jesus, Isaiah, and Immanuel

Matthew’s first “fulfillment quotation” in his account is from [Isaiah 7:14](#).

Matthew 1:22 quotation of Isaiah 7:14	Isaiah 7:14 — Old Greek Septuagint	Isaiah 7:14 — Hebrew Text
Ιδου η παρθενος εν γαστρι εξει και τεξεται υιον, και καλεσουσιν το ονομα αυτου Εμμανουηλ	ιδου η παρθενος εν γαστρι εξει και καλεσεις το ονομα αυτου Εμμανουηλ,	הנה העלמה הרה וילדת בן וקראת שמו עמנו אל:
Look, the virgin will be pregnant and will birth a son, and they will call his name “Emmanuel”	Look, the virgin will be pregnant and will birth a son, and you will call his name “Emmanuel,”	Look, the young woman is pregnant and gives birth to a son, and you will call his name “Immanuel.”
Jesus, Isaiah, and Immanuel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).		

When we compare Matthew’s quoted text of [Isaiah 7:14](#), we find two important differences from the Hebrew text of Isaiah.

- 1. Difference #1: Matthew has “they will call,” while the Hebrew text and Old Greek translation read “you will call,” referring to Isaiah himself.
- 2. Difference #2: Matthew follows the Old Greek translation in translating the Hebrew word *’almah* / עלמה as “virgin” / *παρθενος*, instead of “young woman” / *νεανις*, which is how this Hebrew word is often translated in the Old Greek Septuagint (see [Exod. 2:8](#); [1 Sam. 20:22](#); [Ps. 68:25](#) [67:25]; [Prov. 30:19](#); [Song 1:3](#), [6:8](#)).

However, this translation of “young woman” as “virgin” by the Old Greek translator is not random, and it shows an awareness of an important set of authorially intended literary analogies at work in the Isaiah scroll. Within the key chapters of [Isaiah 5-11](#) and [36-39](#), there are a broad set of intentional hyperlinks that compare the stories of a father (King Ahaz) and his son (King Hezekiah) when they were placed in similar tests of trust in Yahweh’s promises to protect Jerusalem and the future of the seed of David. (The following insights are adapted from Jacob Stromberg, “The Virgin Birth and the Book of Isaiah: Matthew’s Reception of an Isaianic Analogy,” 6-7.)

Ahaz in Isaiah 5-11	Hezekiah in Isaiah 36-39
Isa. 7:1 The Syrians and northern Israelites ally, so that a foreign king (מלך) goes up (עלה) against (על) the city of Jerusalem.	Isa. 36:1 The Assyrian army surrounds Jerusalem so that foreign king (מלך) goes up (עלה) against (על) the city of Jerusalem.
Isa. 7:6 The foreign king seeks to replace the legitimate Davidic king with someone else.	Isa. 36:14-17 The foreign king seeks to replace the legitimate Davidic king with someone else.
Isa. 7:3 Isaiah sends a message to King Ahaz “at the conduit of the upper pool on the highway to the launderer’s field.	Isa. 36:2 “... at the conduit of the upper pool on the highway to the launderer’s field.”
Isa. 7:4, 11 Isaiah says “don’t be afraid” (אל תירא) and offers a “sign” (אות) to confirm God’s promise.	Isa. 37:6, 30 Isaiah says “don’t be afraid” (אל תירא) and offers a sign (אות) to confirm God’s promise.
Isa. 7:14-15 The sign is a son to be born to a “young woman” (עלמה), who will “eat” (אכל) curds and honey until the city’s deliverance.	Isa. 37:30-32 The sign is that the remnant of Jerusalem will “eat” (אכל) plants that sprout “upward” (למעלה) and bear fruit when the city is delivered.
Despite the absence of a man “going into” the “young woman,” she will birth a son who will be a sign of the city’s deliverance and the survival of the son of David.	The king of Assyria will not be allowed to “go into” (בוא אל, Isa. 37:33-34) Jerusalem, who is described as the “virgin daughter Zion” (παρθενος θυγατηρ Σιών, Isa. 37:22).
Isaiah 37:30-35 ³⁰ “Then this shall be the sign for you: you will eat this year what grows of itself, in the second year what springs from the same, and in the third year sow-seed (זרע), reap, plant vineyards and eat their fruit (פרי). ³¹ The surviving remnant of the house of Judah, it will again take root downward and bear fruit (פרי) upward. ³² For out of Jerusalem will go out a remnant, and survivors out of Mount Zion, The zeal of the LORD of hosts will perform this.” ³³ Therefore, thus says the LORD concerning the king of Assyria, “He will not enter into (בוא + אל) this city or shoot an arrow there; and he will not come before it with a shield, or throw up a siege ramp against it. ³⁴ By the way that he came, by the same he will return,	
<i>Ahaz and Hezekiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>	

Ahaz in Isaiah 5-11

Hezekiah in Isaiah 36-39

and **he will not enter into** (בוא + אל) to this city,” declares the LORD.

³⁵ “For I will defend this city to save it for my own sake and for my servant David’s sake.”

Ahaz and Hezekiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The story of Ahaz’s failed faith and the birth of the Immanuel child in his day becomes an analogy for the later successful faith of Ahaz’s son Hezekiah. The son’s faith in Yahweh’s deliverance resulted in the rescue of Jerusalem from the king of Assyria as well as survival of the seed of David.

The poem uttered by [Isaiah 37:30-35](#) about the deliverance of Zion and the seed of David takes on a future-oriented meaning, as the author has depicted the rescue of the future Zion/royal seed on analogy to the deliverance in Hezekiah’s day (see also Stromberg’s important essay, “Figural History in the Book of Isaiah: The Prospective Significance of Hezekiah’s Deliverance from Assyria and Death”).

“[T]he almah of [Isaiah ch. 7](#) functions as a portent of virgin daughter Zion in [ch. 37](#) ... [H]er child, Immanuel, was a sign of the post-Assyrian royal remnant to 'go forth' from her in the manner of a virgin birth, the image of a renewal of Davidic rule, not by the will of man but of God. Reading backwards from referent to portent, then, the Septuagint can be seen as following the historical sense of the text when it translates both בתולה in the oracle given Hezekiah ([37:22](#)) and עלמה in the sign given Ahaz ([7:14](#)) with the same Greek word, παρθενος, 'virgin'—a conclusion extending to παρθενος in Matthew’s version as well ... [T]his entire strategy—involving the Ahaz and Hezekiah narratives—has a prospective significance that points beyond the days of the prophet to a time far removed from his own—a time when God would again intervene in the life of his people to effect a renewal of Davidic rule. In portraying Jesus in precisely these terms, it was no doubt Matthew’s intention to signal that this future had arrived.”

Stromberg, Jacob. “The Virgin Birth and the Book of Isaiah: Matthew’s Reception of an Isaianic Analogy.” 9.

Reflection Question

How does Mary becoming pregnant by the power of the Spirit connect to creation in Genesis 1 and 2 or to the birth of Isaac?

Session 7: Jesus, Isaiah, and Immanuel

Key Takeaways

- Matthew does not view the prophets as offering predictions of specific future events that come to pass through Jesus, but instead sees Jesus' life as bringing to their fullness prophetic promises and hopes.
- Matthew cites the Old Greek version of Isaiah 7:14, tapping into an already existing tradition of interpreting the young woman Isaiah mentions as representing virgin Zion.
- Matthew quotes a specific verse in Isaiah, but he draws on how that verse fits within the entire book of Isaiah and how Isaiah fits within the Hebrew Bible as a whole.



This session covers the notes from session 6

Reflection Question

Does Isaiah 7:14 promise that the Messiah will be born of a virgin? What does Matthew mean by citing this verse?

Session 8: Magi and Herod

Key Takeaways

- Herod I was widely known for his extravagance, paranoia, and cruelty. Matthew immediately links this villainous figure to the power structures of Jerusalem in Jesus' day.
- The Magi represent the fulfillment of the prophetic promise that the nations would recognize the coming of God's rescue for the world.
- Matthew adopts imagery from Isaiah 60 to present Jesus as the new Jerusalem.

Matthew 2:1-12

A ¹ Now, when **Jesus** had **been** born in **Bethle'em** of **Joudaia** ,
in the days of **Herodes the king** ,
look, **magi** from **the eastern regions** arrived in **Hierosoluma** , ² saying,

B "Where is the one **born king** of the **Joudeans** ,
because we saw **his star in the east** ,
and **we have come to bow down to him.**"

A' ³ And when **King Herodes** heard,
he was troubled, and all of **Hierosoluma** with him,

⁴ and having gathered all the chief priests and scribes of the people,
he inquired from them **where** the **messiah** is to be **born** .

⁵ And they said to him
"In **Bethle'em** of **Joudaia** ,
because that's how it was written through the prophets,
⁶ 'And you, **Bethle'em** of the land of **Jouda** ,
you are by no means least among the **rulers** of **Jouda** ,
because from you will come **a ruler** ,

who will shepherd my people, Israel.”

7 Then **Herodes**, having privately called **the magi**,
he learned precisely from them the time of **the shining star**,

A 8 and having sent them to **Bethle’em**, he said,
“As you go make a careful examination about **the child**,
and when you find him, **report to me**,
so that **I too may come and bow down to him.**”

9 And having listened to **the king** they went,
and look, **the star** which they saw **in the east**,
it went ahead of them until going on it stood over the place where **the child** was,

10 and seeing **the star**, they rejoiced with very great joy,
B a 11 and coming into **the house**,
b they saw **the child** with Maria his mother,
c and falling down
d **they bowed down to him**,
c' and opening up their treasures,
d' they brought to him gifts of gold, frankincense, and myrrh,

A' 12 and having been warned in a dream **not to return** to **Herodes**,
they departed by another road unto their own country.

Matthew 2:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

Herod the Great and Ruthless

The Herods were a royal family from Idumea, far southeast of Israel, a tribal kingdom that was forcibly converted to Judaism around 127 B.C.E. by John Hyrcanus II (a Hasmonean ruler over Israel).

Herod I was appointed by the Romans as leader of Galilee first and then later, in 37 B.C.E., over most of Israel as tetrarch (ruler of a 1/4 kingdom). He converted Jerusalem to his rule and installed friends and allies in all of the important positions, including the temple. He supported the Roman emperors so consistently that he kept being rewarded with more and more land onto his kingdom. By 20 B.C.E., he ruled over the entire region formerly ruled by the Jewish Hasmoneans.

Herod engaged in many building projects whose ruins still remain to this day (Caesarea by the sea, Jerusalem, Masada).

Herod's final years (he died in 4 B.C.E.) were fraught with court intrigue, assassination attempts, and mental anguish. He had no clear heir and was unable to name his successor (his 10 wives bore him 15 children). He murdered one of his wives out of fear of a coup, and he had two of his sons, Alexander and Aristobulus, executed for a plot to assassinate their father and seize his throne. He ordered that a number of populist leaders who opposed him be executed on the day he died, to ensure that there would be mourning in the land (see Josephus, *Antiquities of the Jews*, sec. 173-175).

He divided up his kingdom into thirds shortly before his death of an intestinal disease. He appointed Herod Archelaus over Israel, Antipas over Galilee and Perea, and Philip over the rest.

Needless to say, the king's paranoia highlighted by Matthew is entirely in character for what we know of Herod from other historical sources.

"Herod matters for two reasons. First, in his attempt to slaughter the Messiah he is like the Pharaoh of Jewish tradition, who sought to kill the first redeemer, Moses. Secondly, Herod, although he could boast no royal genealogy, was a king, and our evangelist is interested in contrasting his rule and kingdom with the rule and kingdom of Jesus the Davidic Messiah."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2000). [*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel According to Saint Matthew, vol. 1*](#). T&T Clark. 227.

Jerusalem in Trouble

Jerusalem is here introduced for the first time in Matthew's account, and the portrait is not flattering. The city is associated with Herod and his ruthless plans to consolidate power and eliminate rivals. In the story moving forward, Jerusalem becomes identified with Israel's corrupt leadership who will violently oppose Jesus. In fact, [Matthew 2:3](#) is part of a network of hyperlinks throughout the story that portray Jerusalem as a hostile opponent to Jesus.

Matthew 2:3 Instructor's Translation

And when King Herodes heard,
he was **troubled, and all of Ierosoluma** with him,

Matthew 16:21 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began to point out that it was necessary for him to go to **Ierosoluma**,
and to suffer many things by the elders and chief-priests and scribes,
and to be killed,

Matthew 21:10-11 Instructor's Translation

¹⁰ And after he entered into **Ierosoluma**,
all of the city was shaken, saying,

"Who is this one?!"

¹¹ But the crowds said,

"This one is the prophet Iesous,
who is from Nazeret of Galilaias!"

Matthew 23:37 Instructor's Translation

Ierousalem! Ierousalem! The one who killed the prophets,
and who stoned-to-death those sent to her;
how many times I have desired to gather your children together,
in the way a mother-hen gathers her chicks under her wings;
but y'all did not desire it.

Micah Fused With Samuel

The words of the prophet Micah quoted by the chief priests and scribes come from Micah 5:2, but Matthew supplies an additional line to the end of the quotation that comes verbatim from an important story in 2 Samuel 5:1-3.

Matthew 2:6 (quoting Micah 5:2)

And you, Bethlehem, land of Judah,
are by no means least among the leaders of Judah;
for out of you shall come forth a ruler,
who will shepherd my people Israel.

Micah 5:2, 4

² “But as for you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though
little among the clans of Judah, from you one will
go forth for me, to be a ruler in Israel,

his goings forth are from long ago, from the days
of eternity.”

⁴ And he will arise and shepherd his flock in the
strength of the Lord,

2 Samuel 5:1–3

¹ Then all the tribes of Israel came to David at
Hebron and said, “Behold, we are your bone and
your flesh. ² Previously, when Saul was king over
us, you were the one who led Israel out and in.
And the Lord said to you,

‘You will shepherd my people Israel,
and you will be a ruler over Israel.’”

³ So all the elders of Israel came to the king at
Hebron, and King David made a covenant with
them before the Lord at Hebron; then they
anointed David king over Israel.

Micah and Matthew. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The additional line “who/you will shepherd my people” comes verbatim from the Old Greek translation of 2 Samuel 5:2. This is a line spoken by the elders of the non-Judahite tribes who acknowledge David as their divinely appointed king. They appeal to God’s own choice, quoting God’s words that David “will shepherd my people Israel.” They also acknowledge that the previous king, Saul, has now been displaced by David.

This is surely part of the ironic effect that the additional line creates within Matthew’s context, where there is also an illegitimate king with a dubious claim to kingship, namely Herod, to whom these words are being spoken!

It is also important to notice that within the local context of [Micah 5:2-4](#) the same idea appears in different words, namely that this “ruler” from Bethlehem will “arise and shepherd his flock.” In other words, these two passages were already linked together with matching language and imagery, and the fact that Matthew has blended their words together shows that he not only recognized the connection, but he sought to make it explicit and bring out the inner meaning of both texts.

The Messianic Shepherd

In blending the quotes from [Micah 5](#) and [2 Samuel 5](#), Matthew has portrayed Jesus with two of the most iconic messianic images from the Hebrew Scriptures: king and shepherd. Matthew has also, by means of these images, developed one of the major themes of his entire account, namely that Jesus the Son of God is the messianic shepherd king from the house of David.

Matthew will explicitly develop this shepherd theme throughout the story.

Matthew 2:6 Instructor's Translation

And you, Bethle’em of the land of louda,
you are by no means least among the rulers of louda,
because from you will come a **ruler**,
who will shepherd my people, Israel.

Matthew is quoting [Micah 5](#) and [2 Samuel 5](#).

Matthew 9:36 Instructor's Translation

And when he saw **the crowds**, he had compassion on them,
because they were **troubled and scattered**,
like sheep not having a shepherd.

Matthew 10:5-6 Instructor's Translation

⁵ These the twelve Jesus sent,
having instructed them, saying,
“Onto the road of the nations you will not depart,
and into a city of the Samaritans you will not enter,
⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel**,

Matthew 15:24 Instructor's Translation

And he responded saying,
“I was not sent, except to **the lost sheep of the house of Israel.**”

Matthew 18:12-14 Instructor's Translation

¹² How does it seem to you?
If there were to a certain man, **one hundred sheep**,
and **one of them wandered off**,
wouldn’t he leave the ninety-nine on the hills,

and going, seek the wandering-one?

¹³ And whenever it happens that he finds it,
amen, I tell you,
he will rejoice over it,
more than over the ninety-nine who did not wander.

¹⁴ Similarly, **it is not the desire before your Father in the skies,
that one of these little-ones would be lost.**

These images of the “troubled,” “scattered,” and “lost” sheep all derive from the language of the Hebrew prophets, specifically Jeremiah 23 and Ezekiel 34. These prophets, both of whom offered a minority report against the leaders of Israel in the years leading up to Jerusalem’s destruction by Babylon, criticized the leaders of Israel in very similar language.

- Jeremiah 23:1-6 criticizes the priest and kings of Jerusalem for scattering the sheep of Israel through neglect and abuse. God’s response is to gather the sheep under the leadership of new shepherd, specifically a “righteous branch for David.”
- Ezekiel 34 is a similar criticism of Jerusalem’s leaders who feed themselves and “who do not strengthen the weak, nor heal the sick, nor bind up the wounded nor bring back the scattered” (Ezek. 34:4).

Matthew wants us to see the entire ministry of Jesus to Israel in the category of these ancient prophetic hopes of a new royal shepherd from the line of David.

The Magi From the East

The famous “wise men” are called “magi” (Grk. *magos* singular / *magoi* plural: *μαγος* / *μαγοι*).

The term originally designated Persian officials of a priestly standing who specialized in the interpretation of dreams, astronomical signs (i.e., astrologers), and other ritual practices associated with the Zoroastrian religion of the East. The term is used in the Old Greek translation of Daniel to describe Nebuchadnezzar’s court sorcerers (see Dan. 2:2, 10).

By the 1st century C.E., magi was a general term for astrologer and ritual expert. Matthew does not specify if “east” means they are Babylonian, Arabian, or Persian.

Because *magos* has a decidedly negative connotation elsewhere in the New Testament (Acts 8:9-11, 13:6-8), it’s possible that Matthew includes this story to provide a contrast with Israel’s current rulers—while Herod and the current establishment in Jerusalem does not recognize Jesus as Israel’s messianic King, even the mysterious magi of the nations can discern the arrival of God’s Messiah, and they eagerly come!

“Whatever the social and religious unsuitability of magi, the fact that they were not Jews fitted more congenially with Matthew’s universalist agenda. To have the 'King of the Jews' recognized and honored first not by his own people but by representatives of the 'many' who were later to come from east and west to take their place in the kingdom of heaven (Matt. 8:11) appropriately set the scene for the ministry of the Israelite Messiah who would both be rejected by his own people (here foreshadowed by the stance of Herod and 'all Jerusalem,' see on v. 3) and send out his disciples to recruit from all nations (28:19).”

The Magi and the Messiah's Star

The magi associate the star they saw with Israel's king ("we saw his star"). This perhaps alludes to a popular ancient belief in a heavenly herald who would arise to signal the arrival of a new king (see Pliny the Elder, *Natural History*, 2:28; Plato, *Timaeus*, 41D-E; Horace, *Epistles*, 2.2.187).

Also, Matthew likely words their speech in a certain way so that it alludes to multiple Hebrew Bible hyperlinks that connect the rising of a star with the arrival of Israel's messiah and with the dawn of Israel's restoration.

Numbers 24:17 LEB

I see him, but not now;
I behold him, but not near;
a star will tread forth from Jacob,
and a scepter will rise from Israel;

The Magi and Isaiah's New Jerusalem

Matthew deliberately adopts language from Isaiah's depiction of the new Jerusalem and applies it to Messiah Jesus.

Isaiah 60:1-14 LXX/Septuagint

¹ **Shine! Shine** (φωτιζω), Jerusalem, for **your light** (το φως) is come,
and the glory of the Lord has **risen** (ανατελλω) upon you.

² Look! Gloom will cover the earth,
and darkness will be upon the nations,
but **the Lord will appear** (φαινω) **over you**,
and his glory will be seen upon you.

³ **Kings will walk in your light and nations in your splendor ...**

⁵ ... because the wealth of the sea and of **the nations and of the peoples will come to you**.
And present with you will be herds of camels,

⁶ and camels of Midian and of Ephah will cover you.
Everyone from Sheba will **come bearing gold** (χρυσιον),
and they will **carry frankincense** (λιβανος)
and **proclaiming the good news of the Lord's rescue** (το σωτηριον κυριου ευαγγελιουνται) ...

¹⁴ **And the sons of those who made you low and provoked you will go to bending low,**
and **you will be called "City of the Lord," "Zion of the Holy One of Israel."**

"The motif of the pilgrimage of the nations to Zion ... has been messianically transformed—the magi come to pay homage to the king of the Jews ... so that the goal of the pilgrimage is not Jerusalem, but Bethlehem. This modification corresponds to the negative role Jerusalem plays in the Gospel of Matthew ... The coming of the gentiles is no longer conceivable as a pilgrimage to Jerusalem, but has been transformed into a coming to the Messiah."

Reflection Question

What does it mean that Matthew presents Jesus as the new Jerusalem?

Session 9: Out of Egypt

Key Takeaways

- Matthew casts the story of Jesus' birth as a retelling of the birth of Moses and the exodus.
- Just as Moses was adopted into the house of Pharaoh, so Jesus was adopted into the house of David.
- God's pattern of choosing Abraham, Israel, and David challenges our cultural practices of privileging only ourselves and those like us. God chooses one to bring blessing to the many.

Matthew 2:13-23

A 13 And after they departed,
look, **a messenger of the Lord** **shone-in-appearance** to Ioseph **in a dream**, saying,
"Getting up, take **the child** **and his mother**,
and flee **to Egypt** and be there until whenever I speak to you!
For **Herodes** is about **to seek** **the child**, to destroy him."

B 14 And **getting up, he took** **the child** **and his mother** by night,
and **he departed** **to Egypt**,

C 15 and he was there until **the death-end of Herodes**,
in order to **fill-full** **what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet, saying**,
"**From Egypt** I called **my son**."

16 Then (τοτε) **Herodes**, seeing that he had been deceptively-tricked by the **magi**,
he was enraged, very much,
and having sent, he did away with all **the children**,
who were in Bethle'em and in all its districts,
from two years old and below,
according to the time which he learned precisely from the **magi**.

17 **Then** (τοτε) **was** **filled-full** **what was spoken through Ieremias the prophet, saying**,

18 "A voice was heard in Rama,

crying and great grieving;
Rakhel crying for **her children**,
and she does not want to be comforted,
because they are no more.”

19 And after **Herodes came to his death-end**,
look **a messenger of the Lord shone-in-appearance** to Ioseph **in Egypt in a dream**, saying,
A' 20 “**Getting up, take the child and his mother,**
and go to the land of **Israel**,
for those **who seek** the life of **the child** have **died**.”

B' 21 And **getting up, he took the child and his mother,**
and he went to the land of **Israel**,

C' 22 and having heard that **Arkheleos ruled as king** of Ioudaia,
in the place of **his father Herodes**,
he was afraid and he left there,
and having been warned **in a dream**,
he departed into the region of Galilaia,
23 and having come, he lived in a city called “Nazaret,”
in order to fill-full what was spoken through the prophets,
that he would be called a Nazoraios.”

Matthew 2:13-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

This final panel of Matthew 1:18-2:23 has a very clear three-part symmetrical design.

- A — Angel appears, directing Joseph to take Mary and child to Egypt, they do so
 - B — Herod's response (τοτε) + Scripture fulfillment (τοτε)
- A' — Angel appears, directing Joseph to take Mary and child to Israel, they do so

Notice the flight to Egypt and the return to Israel are coordinated so that, in a great reversal, Egypt becomes the place of refuge while Israel is the land of death and danger.

This design also coordinates the father-son pair of Herod the Great and Herod-Archelaos.

An Inverted Exodus and a New Pharaoh

This entire sequence is designed as an inverted Exodus story. The classic characters and scenes have all been changed so that the characters of Matthew's story have surprising correspondences with the Exodus story.

- Jesus and Joseph // Moses
- Herod and Herod-Archelaos // Pharaoh
- Israel // Egypt
- Galilee // Midian

Matthew 2:13-14

¹³ “Getting up, take the child and his mother, and **flee to Egypt** and be there until whenever I speak to you! For **Herodes is about to seek the child, to destroy him.**”

¹⁴ And getting up, he took the child and his mother by night, and **he departed to Egypt**.

Matthew 2:19-20

¹⁹ And after Herodes came to his death-end, look a messenger of the Lord shone-in-appearance to Ioseph in Egypt in a dream, saying,
²⁰ “Getting up, take the child and his mother, **and go to the land of Israel, for those who seek the life of the child have died.**”

Matthew 2:21-23

²¹ And getting up, he took the child and his mother, and he went to the land of Israel,
²² and having heard that Archelaos ruled as king of Ioudaia, in the place of his father Herodes, **he was afraid** and he left there, and having been warned in a dream, **he departed into the region of Galilaia,**
²³ **and having come, he dwelt in a city called “Nazeret”**

Exodus 2:14b-15

^{14b} And **Moshe was afraid,** and said, “Surely, the matter has become known!”
¹⁵ And **Pharaoh** heard of this matter, and **he sought to murder Moshe,** and **Moshe fled** from before the face of Pharaoh, **and he dwelt in the land of Midyan,** and he dwelt by a well.

Exodus 4:19-20

¹⁹ And Yahweh said to Moshe in Midyan, **“Go, return to Egypt, because the men seeking your life have died.”**
²⁰ And Moshe took his wife and his sons, and he had them ride on a donkey, and he returned to the land of Egypt,

Inverted Exodus and New Pharaoh. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

This portrait of Herod as a new Pharaoh is also programmatic for Matthew’s account as a whole, because Herod represents the Jerusalem regime set on “destroying” (ἀπολλύμι) the Messiah. Matthew will later portray Jesus’ opponents with similar language, linking them all back to Herod and thus to Pharaoh.

Matthew 2:13 NASB

“Get up! Take the child and his mother and flee to Egypt, and remain there until I tell you; for Herod is going to search for the child to **destroy** (απολλυμι) him.”

Matthew 12:14 NASB

But the Pharisees went out and conspired against him, as to how they might **destroy** (απολλυμι) him.

Matthew 27:20 NASB*

But the chief priests and the elders persuaded the crowds to ask for Barabbas and to **destroy** (απολλυμι) Jesus.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Out of Egypt I Called My Son”

In [Matthew 2:15](#), we find the third quotation from the Scriptures, a line from [Hosea 11:1](#) where the prophet recalls Israel’s exodus from Egypt in the past. In context, Hosea (in the 8th century B.C.E.) laments Israel’s current state of idolatry and covenant violation, and he warns that they will return to captivity. This is tragic because Israel as a nation is Yahweh’s son who was liberated from Egypt and is now headed toward captivity and slavery again. But this “return” to slavery won’t be to Egypt but to Assyria.

Hosea 11:1-5 LEB

¹ When Israel was a child, I loved him,
and **out of Egypt I called my son.**
² When I called them, they went from my face.
They sacrificed to the Baals, and they sacrificed to idols.
³ And I myself taught Ephraim to walk;
I took them in my arms,
but they did not know that I healed them.
⁴ I drew them with human ties,
with the bands of love.
I was to them like one who lifted up a yoke on their jaws,
though I bent down to them and let them eat.
⁵ **He will return to the land of Egypt,**
and Assyria will be his king,
because they refused to return.

Matthew most likely adopts this line from Hosea not only because of the recall of the exodus from Egypt, but also because of the designation of Israel as God’s son. Also, Hosea shows that the Egyptian slavery of the past has become a symbol of the coming Assyrian enslavement.

This text from Hosea is also hyperlinked to an important text in the Exodus story itself, where Moses’ own deliverance from the Egyptian Pharaoh through the waters ([Exod. 1-4](#)) is designed as a narrative foreshadowing of all Israel’s deliverance through the waters ([Exod. 5-15](#)).

Exodus 4:22-23 LEB

²² And you must say to Pharaoh, “Thus says Yahweh, ‘**Israel is my son, my firstborn.**’

²³ And I said to you, ‘Release my son and let him serve me,’ but you refused to release him. Look, I am about to kill your son, your firstborn.”

Another relevant set of hyperlinks for Matthew’s quotation of [Hosea 11:1](#) consists of passages that anticipate a future king from the lineage of David, who will undergo an “exodus” that is set on analogy to Israel’s exodus from Egypt.

Numbers 24:5-8 LEB

⁵ How good are your tents, O Jacob,
your dwellings, O Israel!

⁶ They are spread out like valleys,
like gardens on a river,
like aloes planted by Yahweh,
like cedars at the waters.

⁷ He will pour water from his buckets,
and his offspring will be like many waters;
his king will be higher than Agag,
and **his kingdom** will be exalted.

⁸ God, **who brings him out from Egypt**,
is like the strength of a wild ox for him.

Psalms 2:7-8 LEB

⁷ I will tell the decree; Yahweh said to me:

“You are my son;
today I have birthed you.

⁸ Ask from me and I will make the nations your heritage,
and your possession the ends of the earth.

It’s useful to reconstruct the network of allusions to help us see how Matthew’s mind worked and how he saw various parts of the Hebrew Bible as interconnected.

[Matthew 2:15](#) quotes [Hosea 11:1](#), which is hyperlinked to [Exodus 4:26](#), which is portrayed by [Numbers 24:5-6](#) as a narrative analogy between Moses’ exodus ([Exod. 1-4](#)), Israel’s exodus ([Exod. 5-15](#)), and the deliverance of the future divine son of David ([Ps. 2, 18](#)).

“Rachel Weeping for Her Children”

Matthew’s fourth Old Testament quotation in the introduction comes from [Jeremiah 31:15](#), where the prophet portrays the matriarch of Israel grieving for the downfall and destruction of her children. Matthew connects this quotation with the death of the children of Bethlehem who were ruthlessly murdered by King Herod.

As in the previous Old Testament quote, Matthew quotes this text because it has hyperlinked associations with many other stories in the Hebrew Bible that provide meaningful narrative analogies with the story of

Jesus and Herod.

In context, Jeremiah portrays Rachel's weeping as a sign of Israel's devastation that will soon come to an end.

Jeremiah 31:15-16 LEB

¹⁵ Thus says Yahweh,

**"A voice is heard in Ramah,
lamentation, the weeping of bitterness.
Rachel is weeping for her children;
she refuses to be comforted because of her children,
for they are no more."**

¹⁶ Thus says Yahweh:

"Restrain your voice from weeping,
and your eyes from tears,
for there is a reward for your work," declares Yahweh,
"and they will return from the land of the enemy."

In context, Jeremiah is appealing to the story of Rachel weeping for her lost sons and refusing to be comforted. This recalls two moments in Genesis that provide the language for Jeremiah 31:15-16.

Genesis 30:22-24 NASB

²² Then **God remembered Rachel**, and God gave heed to her and opened her womb. ²³ **So she conceived and bore a son** and said, "God has taken away my reproach." ²⁴ **She named him Joseph**, saying, "May the LORD give me another son."

Genesis 35:16-19 NASB

¹⁶ Then they journeyed from Bethel; and when there was still some distance to go to Ephrath, **Rachel began to give birth and she suffered severe labor.** ¹⁷ **When she was in severe labor** the midwife said to her, "Do not fear, for now you have another son." ¹⁸ It came about as her soul was departing (for she died), that **she named him Ben-oni; but his father called him Benjamin.** ¹⁹ So **Rachel died and was buried** on the way to Ephrath (that is, **Bethlehem**).

Genesis 37:33-35 NASB

³³ Then he examined it and said, "It is my son's tunic. A wild beast has devoured him; Joseph has surely been torn to pieces!" ³⁴ So Jacob tore his clothes, and put sackcloth on his loins and mourned for his son many days. ³⁵ Then all his sons and all his daughters arose to comfort him, but **he refused to be comforted.** And he said, "Surely I will go down to Sheol in mourning for my son." So **his father wept for him.**

Genesis 42:13 Instructor's Translation

But they said, "Your servants are twelve brothers in all, the sons of one man in the land of Canaan; and behold, the youngest is with our father today, **and one is no more.**"

Genesis 42:31-32 NASB

³¹ “But we said to him, ‘We are honest men; we are not spies. ³² We are twelve brothers, sons of our father; **one is no more**, and the youngest is with our father today in the land of Canaan.’”

Genesis 44:20 NASB

“We said to my lord, ‘We have an old father and a little child of his old age. Now **his brother is no more, so he alone is left of his mother, and his father loves him.**’”

In this network of texts, we have a number of narrative analogies working together.

- Rachel, the mother of Joseph, was Jacob’s “beloved” wife who died an untimely death.
- As she gave birth to Benjamin, she grieved and died, and she was buried near Bethlehem.
- When Joseph was betrayed by his brothers and presumed dead, Jacob refused to be comforted and wept.
- Three times Joseph is said to be “no more.”
- The final time this phrase appears, we are told that Benjamin is the only son left from Rachel, and he is especially beloved.

This network of texts in Genesis explores just how tragic Israel’s fate has become among the nations. Brother betraying brother, tragic deaths and murders, all the sad result of humanity choosing to define good and bad by their own wisdom. And it leads Jacob’s family into exile ... in Egypt!

Jeremiah 31 brings together these themes and sees Rachel (buried near Bethlehem, birthplace of David and Jesus) weeping like Jacob over her lost children. In Jeremiah’s context, this applies to the lost generations of the Babylonian exile and destruction of Jerusalem. But the fact that Jeremiah adopts the image of Rachel and portrays her in the mourning role of Jacob from the Joseph story shows that the prophet wants us to see how these stories of the past prefigure the large-scale tragedies of Israel’s story in the future. The tragedy of Babylonian exile was yet another cycle of betrayal and death in Israel’s story, so that the matriarch now weeps from the grave over her children.

Matthew adopts the lines from Jeremiah 31:15 with full awareness of its hyperlinked nature, as he too is exploring an act of betrayal (Israel’s king murdering his people’s children) that led to another exile in Egypt (the Messiah’s). The analogy between these Old Testament stories (Rachel, Jacob, Joseph, and Jeremiah) and the story of Herod and Jesus runs deep. These stories illuminate each other and point forward to a hopeful resolution.

“He Will Be Called a Nazoraioi”

After returning from Egypt, Joseph leads his new family to Nazareth in Galilee. Archaeologists estimate that the town had a population of 500.

In this geographical move, Matthew sees another connection to the story of the Scriptures. This is the only quotation that he attributes to “the prophets” as a group. This makes sense, because there is nowhere in the Hebrew or Greek Bible that contains the line: “He will be called a Nazoraioi.” Also, Matthew has adapted the quotation formula by adding the conjunction “that” (ὅτι) before the phrase, showing that “he would be called a Nazoraioi” is not a quotation proper, but a reference to an idea or theme found in the Prophets.

It is most likely that Matthew has provided a riddle for the reader that leads to multiple hyperlinks in the Hebrew Bible, but all roads lead back to [Isaiah 4:2-3](#) and [11:1-2](#).

Isaiah 4:2-3 Instructor's Translation

² In that day,
the **sprout of YHWH** will be
for beauty and for honor,
and the fruit of the land will be
for pride and for beauty
for the escaped-remnant of Yisrael.

³ And the one remaining in Zion,
and the one left-over in Yerushalayim,
he will be called a holy one,
everyone who is written for life in Yerushalayim.

Isaiah 11:1 NASB

Then **a shoot** will spring from the stem of Jesse,
and **a branch** (Heb. *netser* / נצר) from his roots will bear fruit.

These two texts are deeply connected in the design of [Isaiah 1-12](#) because both portray the growth of a messianic plant connected with a faithful remnant in Jerusalem that will become the seed of a renewed Israel who will spread the Eden blessing to the nations.

1. Meaning #1: “branch/shoot” rhymes in Hebrew with the name of the town “Nazeret.”
 - The word shoot in [Isaiah 11:1](#) is *netser* in Hebrew (likely pronounced *natsr* in the 1st century). This provides an almost exact wordplay: The *netser* / נצר is from *natseret* / נצרת!
2. Meaning #2: “he will be called a holy one” = “he will be called a Nazirite!”
 - In the Old Greek Septuagint, we find a curious feature: When the figure of the “Nazirite” (Heb. *nazir* / נזיר = “a set-apart one”) appears, the translators sometimes simply transliterate it with the word “Naziraion” (Grk. *ναζιραιος*, see [Judg. 13:7](#), [16:17](#)), but other times they interpret the word instead and so render the word as “the holy one of God” (*αγιος θεου*, see Codex A and B for [Judg. 13:7](#) and [16:17](#)).
 - This is significant because Jesus himself is called “the holy one of God” multiple times in the New Testament ([Mark 1:24](#), [Luke 4:34](#), [John 6:69](#)). In other words, Jesus was viewed as a type of Nazirite by the earliest Christians.
 - While Jesus was no ascetic (he regularly drank wine), he did at his final Passover vow to never drink again until the Kingdom of God has arrived ([Matt. 26:29](#)), and he refused wine-vinegar during his crucifixion ([Matt. 27:48](#)).

Reflection Question

What parallels does Matthew draw between Jesus’ story and Moses or the exodus?

Session 10: The Nazarene

Key Takeaways

- Quoting from Hosea, who himself frames Israel's situation in the language and imagery of the exodus, Matthew continues the tradition of interpreting current events through the lens of Israel's Scriptures.
- The deeper layers of meaning Matthew constructs through these references enrich the more direct parts of his message. The text offers much from a simple reading, and it holds riches for a lifetime of deep meditation.
- The term *Nazoraïos* (Nazarene, Matt. 2:23) may connect Jesus to the promise of a "branch/shoot" from the line of David (Isa. 11:1), or it may link him to the Nazirite vow (Num. 6:1-21), a most holy commitment. The ambiguity may invite us to make both comparisons.



This session covers the notes from session 9

Reflection Question

Do Matthew's quotations help or hinder your understanding of his message? Do you need to understand all of the references to understand what he is trying to tell you?



Module 3: Jesus' Ministry Begins

SESSIONS 11-16

Explore the beginning of Jesus' ministry. Discover John the Baptist's role, Jesus' baptism, and his powerful message of the Kingdom of Heaven.

Session 11: John the Baptist

Key Takeaways

- Matthew portrays John as the messenger anticipated by Isaiah who will announce the coming of Yahweh to restore his captive people (Isa. 40:3-5).
- John's speech is full of quotes and phrases from the Prophets, recalling repeated themes of God's judgment and God's promise of rescue and restoration.
- Water and fire are complex symbols, representing both judgment and hope, death, and purification.

The Commissioning of the Messiah

A - Matthew 3:1-17

- a - **3:1-6** John **in the wilderness**, a voice calling, Jerus. & Judea come, **"repent, Kingdom of God has arrived!"**, **Old Testament quote 6 (Isa. 40)**
- b - **3:7-12** Zadokites come, John's speech: Who are Abraham's children? Baptism of Spirit & fire
- a' - **3:13-17** Baptism of Jesus: voice from the skies, Spirit descends, "you are my **Son**."

B - Matthew 4:1-11

- a - **4:1** Jesus **in the wilderness**, tested by **slanderer** for 40 days
- b - **4:2-10** Three tests of Jesus' loyalty, "If you are the **Son** of God..." + **3 Old Testament quotes (Deut.)**
- a' - **4:11** **Slanderer** leaves Jesus, **angels** come and serve

A' - Matthew 4:12-17

- **4:12-17** Jesus goes to Nazareth, **"repent, Kingdom of God has arrived"** + **Old Testament quote 7 (Isa. 9:1)**, **light "shining"**

Matthew 3:1-4:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

This third and final panel of Matthew's introduction (Matt. 1:1-4:17) speeds the clock forward a few decades and focuses on the circumstances that lead to Jesus' entrance onto the scene, beginning with John the Immerser's arrival.

Notice how the entire unit has a three-part shape in a symmetrical design.

- A - John arrives in the wilderness announcing the arrival of the Kingdom of God (Isaiah 40 quote).

- B - Jesus is tested in the wilderness.
- A' - Jesus arrives in Galilee announcing the arrival of the Kingdom of God ([Isaiah 9 quote](#)).

This symmetrical design makes a clear connection and comparison between John and Jesus and their respective messages. Matthew wants to establish continuity between the two figures so that Jesus takes his cue from the renewal movement that John began. But also, Matthew wants to show how both of them continue the script anticipated by Isaiah.

Matthew has also placed key links between A and B.

- A - John arrives in the wilderness. // B - Jesus enters into the wilderness for his test.
- A - John's baptism establishes Jesus as the Son of God. // B - Jesus' status as the Son of God is questioned and tested in the wilderness.
- A - The Spirit of the Father descends upon Jesus at his baptism. // B - The Spirit leads Jesus into the wilderness so that his loyalty to the Father can be tested.

Reflection Question

Reflect on the symbols of water and fire in John's words in [Matthew 3:7-12](#). In what ways are fire and water similar or different? Are they signs of good things or bad?

Session 12: The Baptism of Jesus

Key Takeaways

- Through Hebrew Bible references, Matthew places Jesus in the position of both Yahweh and Yahweh's servant.
- The voice of the Father affirms Jesus' identity as David's son, the messianic king; Abraham's son, the seed of promise; and Yahweh's suffering servant as described by Isaiah.
- Jesus fills full righteousness by going beyond what is strictly required and standing in the gap for vulnerable humanity. He does this by walking through the waters of death with us.

Matthew 3:1-17

¹ Now, in those days **ioannes** **the immerser** arrived,
announcing in **the wilderness** of **loudaia** ,
² saying,
b " **Change direction** !
A Because **the kingdom of the skies** has come near!"
³ For **this is what was spoken through Esaias the prophet**, saying,
a' "A voice calling in **the wilderness**,
prepare the way of **the Lord** ,
make straight his paths."

B ⁴ Now, **ioannes** himself had his clothing from the hair of camels,
and an animal-skin belt was around his waist,
and his food was grasshoppers and wild honey.

A' ⁵ Then, there came out to him Hierosoluma,
and all **loudaia**
and all the surrounding region of **the lordanes**,
⁶ and they were **immersed** in **the lordanes river** by him,
while **confessing their moral failures** .

7 And seeing many of the Pharisaions and Saddoukaions coming out to his **immersion**, he said to them,

“You **seed** of snakes !

Who directed you to flee from **the coming anger** ?!

8 So then, **produce fruit** worthy of a **change-of-direction** ,

9 and don’t suppose you can say to yourselves,

‘We have **Abra’am** as a **father**.’

For I tell you that God is able to raise up from these stones **children** for Abra’am !

10 For **the axe** is already laid at the root of the trees!

For every **tree** that does not **produce good fruit** will be cut down, and into the **fire** it will be tossed!

11 For I **immerse** y’all in **water** for a **change-of-direction** ,

but the one coming after me is more strong than me, whose sandal I am not worthy to carry.

He will **immerse** you with the **Holy Spirit** and **fire** ,

12 whose **threshing-fork** is in his hand,

and he will clear out his threshing floor,

and he will gather his **wheat** into the store-house,

but the grain-husks he will **burn** with **unextinguishable fire** .”

13 Then Iesous arrived from Galilaias at **the lordanes**, to **Ioannes**, to be **immersed** by him,

14 but **Ioannes** **prevented him**, saying,

a “I need to be **immersed** by you, and you would come to me?!”

15 But responding Iesous said to him,

b “**Allow** it now!

For this is what’s appropriate for us, in order to **fill-full** all doing-right.”

a’ **Then he allowed him.**

16 And, after being **immersed**, Iesous immediate came up from **the water**,

A' and look, **the skies** were opened for him,
and he saw the **spirit of God** coming down like a dove,
and coming upon him,
17 and look, a voice from **the skies** was speaking,
"This is **my son** ,
the beloved one,
in him I have delight."

Matthew 3:1-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

A 3:1 Now, in those days **ioannes** **the immerser** arrived,
announcing in **the wilderness** of **loudaia** ,

B 2 saying,
" **Change direction** !
Because **the kingdom of the skies** has come near!"

A' 3 For **this is what was spoken through Esaias the prophet**, saying,
"A voice calling in **the wilderness**,
prepare the way of **the Lord** ,
make straight his paths."

4 Now, **ioannes** himself had his clothing from the hair of camels,
and an animal-skin belt was around his waist,
and his food was grasshoppers and wild honey.

5 Then, there came out to him Hierosoluma,
and all **loudaia**
and all the surrounding region of **the lordanes**,
6 and they were **immersed** in **the lordanes river** by him,
while **confessing their moral failures** .

Matthew 3:1-6. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

⁷ And seeing many of the Pharisaions and Saddoukaions coming out to his **immersion**,
he said to them,

A "You **seed** of snakes !
Who directed you to flee from **the coming anger** ?!

⁸ So then, **produce fruit** worthy of a **change-of-direction**,

⁹ and don't suppose you can say to yourselves,

B 'We have **Abra'am** as a **father**.'
For I tell you that God is able to raise up from these stones **children** **for Abra'am** !

¹⁰ For **the axe** is already laid at the root of the trees!

A' For every **tree** that does not **produce good fruit** will be cut down,
and into the **fire** it will be tossed!

¹¹ For I **immerse** y'all in **water** for a **change-of-direction**,
but the one coming after me is more strong than me,
whose sandal I am not worthy to carry.
He will **immerse** you with the **holy spirit** and **fire**,

¹² whose **threshing-fork** is in his hand,
and he will clear out his threshing floor,
and he will gather his **wheat** into the store-house,
but the grain-husks he will **burn** with **unextinguishable fire**."

Matthew 3:7-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

John the Messenger and Moses and Elijah

Luke's gospel account provides us with the only biographical information we have about John in the New Testament: He is from a priestly lineage, he was dedicated as a Nazirite from birth, and he was a relative of Jesus (Luke simply mentions that Mary and Elizabeth were "relatives" [Grk. συγγενεις], not necessarily cousins, see [Luke 1:36](#)).

Matthew's portrait of John's identity makes more usage of hyperlinks from the Scriptures, all of them converging on a related set of texts and themes. [Isaiah 40](#) is the springboard text, but it is linked to many others that explain Matthew's introduction to John.

Isaiah 40:1-5 NASB

¹ "Comfort, O comfort my people," says your God.

² "Speak kindly to Jerusalem;
and call out to her, that her warfare has ended,
that her iniquity has been removed,
that she has received of the LORD's hand
double for all her sins."

³ **A voice is calling,**

**"In the wilderness clear the way for Yahweh;
make smooth a highway** in the desert for our God.

⁴ Let every valley be lifted up,
and every mountain and hill be made low;
and let the rough ground become a plain,
and the rugged terrain a broad valley;

⁵ then the glory of Yahweh will be revealed,
and all flesh will see it together;
for the mouth of the LORD has spoken."

Malachi 3:1-3 NASB

¹ "Behold, I am going to send **my messenger**,
and **he will prepare the way before me**.
And the LORD, whom you seek,
he will suddenly come to his temple;
and the messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight, behold, he is coming,"
says the LORD of hosts.

² "But **who can endure the day of his coming?**
And who can stand when he appears?
For **he is like a refiner's fire** and like fullers' soap.

³ He will sit as a smelter and purifier of silver,
and he will purify **the sons of Levi** and refine them like gold and silver,
so that they may present to the LORD offerings in righteousness."

Malachi 4:4-6 NASB

⁴ "Remember the law of Moses my servant, even the statutes and ordinances which I commanded him in Horeb for all Israel.

⁵ Behold, I am going to send you **Elijah the prophet** before **the coming of the great and terrible day of the LORD**.

⁶ **He will change the direction/restore (Heb. *shuv* / שׁוּב) the hearts** of the fathers to their children and the hearts of the children to their fathers, so that I will not come and smite the land with a curse."

2 Kings 1:7-8 NASB

⁷ He said to them, "What kind of man was he who came up to meet you and spoke these words to you?"

⁸ They answered him, "He was **a hairy man with a leather belt bound about his loins.**" And he said, "It is Elijah the Tishbite."

Matthew portrays John as the messenger anticipated by Isaiah who will announce the coming of Yahweh to restore his captive people.

This opening paragraph of Isaiah 40 (the first scroll of the Prophets) is closely linked to the final paragraph of Malachi (the final unit of the last scroll of the Prophets), where the same event is anticipated. But in Malachi 4, the identity of the voice is specified to be "Elijah the prophet." Malachi lived centuries after Elijah the Tishbite died, and so it's clear that Malachi is using Elijah as a symbol for the "prophet like Moses" who Moses himself anticipated in the Torah (see Deut. 18:15-17).

Matthew himself makes this identification with Elijah explicit later in the Gospel (see Matt. 11:10, 14; 17:11-13).

Just as Moses and Elijah confronted a faithless generation of Israel with the arrival of God as Israel's divine King, so now John is preparing Israel for the Lord's arrival once more.

The Dead Sea Scrolls Connection

"Rule of the Community (1QS Column 8:1)

1 In the Community council (there shall be) twelve men and three priests, perfect in everything that has been revealed from all

2 the law to implement truth, justice, judgment, compassionate love and unassuming behaviour of one to another,

3 to preserve faithfulness in the land with firm purpose and **repentant spirit** in order to atone for sin by doing justice

4 and undergoing trials, and to walk with everyone in the measure of the truth and the regulation of the time.

When these things exist in Israel

5 the Community council shall be founded on truth, Blank to be an everlasting plantation, a holy house for Israel and the foundation of the holy of

6 holies for Aaron, true witnesses for the judgment and chosen by the will (of God) to atone for the land and to render

7 the wicked their retribution. Blank This (the Community) is the tested rampart, the precious cornerstone that does not Blank

8 /whose foundations/ shake or tremble from their place. Blank (It will be) the most holy dwelling

9 for Aaron with eternal knowledge of the covenant of justice and in order to offer a pleasant /aroma/; and it will be a house of perfection and truth in Israel

10 in order to establish {/.../} a covenant in compliance with the everlasting decrees. /And these will be accepted in order to atone for the land and to decide the judgment of the wickedness {in perfect behaviour} and there will be no iniquity/. **When these have been established in the foundation of the**

Community for two full years in perfect behaviour

11 **/they will be segregated/ (like) holy ones in the midst of the council of the men of the Community.** And every matter hidden from Israel but which has been found out by

12 the Interpreter, he should not keep hidden from them for fear of a spirit of desertion. Blank And when

these have become /a community/ in Israel

13 /in compliance with these arrangements/ **they are to be segregated from within the dwelling of the men of sin to walk to the desert in order to open there** His path.

14 **As it is written (Isa 40:3):**

«In the desert, prepare the way of **, straighten in the steppe a roadway for our God».**

15 **This is the study of the law wh[i]ch he commanded through the hand of Moses**, in order to act in compliance with all that has been revealed from age to age,

16 and according to what the prophets have revealed through his holy spirit. Blank And anyone of the men of the Community, the covenant of

17 the Community, who insolently shuns anything at all commanded, cannot approach the **pure** food of the men of holiness,

18 and cannot know anything of their counsels until his deeds have been **cleansed** from every depravity, walking in perfect behaviour.”

García Martínez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J. C. (1999). [*“The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition \(translations\)”*](#). Eerdmans. 89-91.

The Kingdom of the Skies is Near!

Matthew introduces John and his message with a key phrase that will be found in Jesus’ mouth later in chapter 4. God’s Kingdom is a key theme in the Hebrew Bible. The association with the skies as the place of God’s throne is a common image in Israel’s Scriptures.

Psalm 103:19 Instructor's Translation

The LORD has established **his throne in the skies**, and **his kingdom** rules over all.

Psalm 145:10-13 NASB

¹⁰ All your works shall give thanks to you, O LORD, and your godly ones shall bless you.

¹¹ They shall speak of **the glory of your kingdom** and talk of your power;

¹² to make known to the sons of men your mighty acts and the glory of the majesty of **your kingdom**.

¹³ **Your kingdom** is an **everlasting kingdom**, and your dominion endures throughout all generations.

Daniel 4:2-3 NASB

² It has seemed good to me to declare the signs and wonders which the Most High God has done for me. ³ How great are his signs and how mighty are his wonders! **His kingdom** is an **everlasting kingdom** and his dominion is from generation to generation.

Daniel 4:34 NASB

But at the end of that period, I, Nebuchadnezzar, raised my eyes toward heaven and my reason returned to me, and I blessed the Most High and praised and honored him who lives forever; for **his dominion is an everlasting dominion** ...

Note that “kingdom of the skies” here does not refer to a place where people go after they die. Rather, it describes the royal presence and will of God that has come down from Heaven to make itself felt here on Earth.

The idea of God's heavenly reign becoming realized on earth is what Daniel 7 is all about.

Daniel 7:13-14 NASB

¹³ I kept looking in the night visions,
and behold, with the clouds of heaven
one like a Son of Man was coming,
and he came up to the Ancient of Days
and was presented before him.

¹⁴ And to **him was given dominion** (שלטן),
glory and **a kingdom** (מלכו),
that all the peoples, nations and men of every language
might serve him.
His dominion is an everlasting dominion
which will not pass away;
and **his kingdom** is one
which will not be destroyed.

Daniel 7:18 Instructor's Translation

But the saints of the Highest One will receive **the kingdom**
and possess **the kingdom** forever, for all ages to come.

Daniel 7:27 NASB

Then the sovereignty, the dominion and the greatness of all the kingdoms under the whole heaven
will be given to the people of the saints of the Highest One;
his kingdom will be an everlasting kingdom, and all the dominions will serve and obey him.

By making John the announcer of the arrival of Heaven's Kingdom, Matthew draws a straight line from John to Jesus to the disciples and the announcement of the apostles.

Matthew 3:1-2 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now, in those days Ioannes the immerser arrived,
announcing in the wilderness of Ioudaia,
² saying, "**Change direction!**
Because **the kingdom of the skies has come near!**"

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began to announce and say,
"**Change direction!**
Because **the kingdom of the skies has come near!**"

Matthew 10:5-7 Instructor's Translation

⁵ These the twelve Iesous sent,
having instructed them, saying,
"Onto the road of the nations you will not depart,

and into a city of the Samaritans you will not enter,
⁶ but rather go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel,
⁷ and as you go, announce, saying,
'The kingdom of the skies has come near!'"

Just as John's announcement is for all Israel, Jesus and the apostles announce their message to all of the "lost sheep of Israel" (see [Matt. 10:6](#) and [15:24](#)).

Immersion, Repentance, and Confession of Sin

In the Hebrew Bible, ritual washing was required of the priests and Levites before approaching God's presence in the temple (see [Lev. 16:4, 24](#)), and it was also required of Israelites who had completed a ritual of purification and had renewed access to the temple courtyard (see [Lev. 12-15](#)).

Within the Hebrew Bible, this ritual immersion is itself linked to the de-creation and re-creation theme that is developed within the Torah and Prophets, where passage through the water and/or fire is an image of judgment, divine mercy, and purification.

- [Genesis 1](#): The dry land is delivered from the waters and established as an Eden outpost.
- [Genesis 6-9](#): Noah and his family are delivered through the de-creation waters into a new Eden.
- [Genesis 19](#): Lot and his family are delivered through the de-creation fire.
- [Exodus 14-15](#): Moses leads Israel through the waters and to Mount Sinai for a covenant ceremony.

In the Second Temple period, Israelites began to extend this symbolism so that individuals might go through a ritual immersion as a symbol of repentance and renewal of commitment to God.

- The *Sibylline Oracles* 4.165 say: "Wash your bodies in rivers, stretch out your hands to heaven for forgiveness ..."
- Josephus describes the Essenes (likely the same group at Qumran connected to the Dead Sea Scrolls) this way: "After which they assemble themselves together again into one place; and when they have clothed themselves in white veils, they then bathe their bodies in cold water. And after this purification is over ..." (*Jewish War* 2.8.4, sec. 129).
- Josephus also describes John: "John, who was called the Baptist; for Herod slew him, who was a good man, and commanded the Jews to exercise virtue, both as to righteousness towards one another, and piety towards God, and so to come to baptism; for that the washing would be acceptable to him, if they made use of it, not in order to the putting away of some sins only, but for the purification of the body; supposing still that the soul was thoroughly purified beforehand by righteousness" (*Jewish Antiquities*, 18.116-118).

Fire, Fruit, and Immersion in the Spirit

John's Audience

Notice that Matthew specifies the two groups that elicit John's anger, the Phariseans and Sadduceans. These two groups represent the most powerful and enduring covenant institutions in Israel's culture.

- Pharisaians = guardians and teachers of Torah and the covenant
- Saddoukaians = priests and facilitators of Israel's worship in the temple

John's message in [Matthew 3:7-12](#) is itself a collage of hyperlinked texts from the Hebrew Bible that focus on the compromised status of Israel among the nations.

- "seed of snakes": [Genesis 3:15](#)
- "make good fruit": [Genesis 2-3](#)
- seed-fruit-children of Abraham: [Genesis 12, 15, 17](#)
- Israel as a compromised tree producing bad fruit: [Isaiah 5:1-7](#), [Micah 7:1-6](#)
- The day of divine justice as a threshing floor where wheat and chaff are separated: [Psalm 1](#)
- A day of Yahweh's anger coming upon Israel for violating their covenant commitment: [Malachi 3-4](#)

Malachi 3:1-3 NASB

¹ "Behold, I am going to send **my messenger**, and **he will prepare the way before me**.

And the Lord, whom you seek,

he will suddenly come to his temple;

and the messenger of the covenant, in whom you delight, behold, he is coming,"

says the LORD of hosts.

² "But **who can endure the day of his coming?**

And who can stand when he appears?

For **he is like a refiner's fire** and like fullers' soap.

³ He will sit as a smelter and purifier of silver,

and he will purify **the sons of Levi** and refine them like gold and silver,

so that they may present to the LORD offerings in righteousness."

Malachi 4:4-6 NASB

⁴ Remember the law of Moses My servant,

even the statutes and ordinances

which I commanded him in Horeb for all Israel.

⁵ Behold, I am going to send you **Elijah the prophet**
before **the coming of the great and terrible day of the Lord**.

⁶ **He will change the direction/restore (Heb. *shuv* / שׁוּב) the hearts** of the fathers to their children
and the hearts of the children to their fathers,
so that I will not come and smite the land with a curse.

All these texts describe a coming act of purifying divine justice upon Israel, akin to the warnings of Israel's prophets. But notice how the outer frames of John's speech ([v. 7b-10](#) and [12](#)) both speak of a separation between the good and bad trees, and the wheat and the chaff. The central panel speaks of that separation in yet another way.

- John's water baptism is about the washing away and "death" of Israel's sins as they pass through the waters.
- The Messiah's baptism will bring a purifying fire to Israel (as in [Mal. 3-4](#)), which will also separate between the faithful and unfaithful within Israel. Here, John brings together two important framing texts

from Isaiah 1-4.

Isaiah 1:27-31 NASB

²⁷ Zion will be redeemed with justice
and her **repentant ones** with righteousness.

²⁸ But transgressors and sinners will be crushed together,
and those who forsake the Lord will come to an end.

²⁹ Surely you will be ashamed of **the oaks** which you have desired,
and you will be embarrassed at **the gardens** which you have chosen.

³⁰ For you will be like **an oak** whose leaf fades away
or as **a garden** that has no water.

³¹ The strong man will become tinder, his work also a spark.
Thus they shall both **burn together**
and there will be **none to extinguish them**.

Isaiah 4:2-4 NASB

² In that day the Branch of the LORD will be beautiful and glorious, and the fruit of the earth will be the pride and the adornment of the survivors of Israel. ³ It will come about that he who is left in Zion and remains in Jerusalem will be called holy—everyone who is recorded for life in Jerusalem. ⁴ When the LORD has **washed away the filth** of the daughters of Zion and **rinsed the bloodshed of Jerusalem** from her midst, **by the spirit of judgment and the spirit of burning**,

John's message announces the arrival of the "Branch of the Lord" who will bring a great "burning fire" that will purify Israel. Some will be consumed, others will endure. It all depends on how they respond.

This means that the "spirit" and "fire" of John's announcement could refer to:

1. spirit = [positive] Christian baptism (as in 28:19-20) and fire = [negative] judgment on Jerusalem (as in 25:41)
2. spirit [negative] and fire [negative] both refer to the coming purifying judgment on Jerusalem

Fulfilling All Righteousness

¹³ Then Jesus arrived from Galilias at **the Jordanes**,
to **loannes**, to be **immersed** by him,

a ¹⁴ but **loannes prevented him**,

b saying,
"I need to **immersed** by you,
and you would come to me?!"

b' 15 But responding Jesus said to him,
 “Allow it now!
 For this is what’s appropriate for us,
 in order to **fill-full** all doing-right.”

a' **Then he allowed him.**

16 And, after being **immersed**,
Jesus immediately came up from **the water**,
and look, **the skies** were opened for him,
and he saw the **spirit of God** coming down like a dove,
and coming upon him,
17 and look, a voice from **the skies** was speaking,
 “This is **my son**,
 the beloved one,
 in him I have delight.”

Matthew 3:13-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

Matthew 3:14-15 is an episode unique to Matthew among the Gospels. Matthew’s account addresses a problem raised by the fact that Jesus was immersed by John, when Jesus had nothing to “repent” from and was in fact John’s superior (which John himself recognizes).

This episode brings us close to the heart of Matthew’s claims about Jesus’ identity.

- “Righteousness” in Matthew is about Israel’s obligation to do right by God and neighbor in covenant communal relationships. This is consistently what righteousness means in Matthew (see Matt. 5:6, 10, 20; 6:1, 33).
- “Fulfilling” (Grk. *pleroo*) in Matthew has to do with how Jesus as Israel’s Messiah takes up what was unfinished and unresolved in Israel’s story and carries it to completion.
 - “fulfill” in the Scriptural quotes in Matthew 1-4 and 26-28
 - “fulfilling” the Torah in Matthew 5:17-21

Jesus “fulfills all doing-what-is-right” by identifying himself, as the divine Son, with Israel’s long history of suffering and death that resulted from their sins. Jesus enters into the “death-waters” in solidarity with his people, trusting that the Father will deliver him into Eden-life out the other side.

“As the son of God, [Jesus] is bound to the will of the Father, so that his divine sonship is manifest in his obedience to God. In the passion this leads to his not making use of his power to save himself from his enemies. So too in the baptism, Jesus lays his superior status aside and subordinates himself to the will of the Father, in that he allows his rightful exalted status as Son of God to remain hidden in his human existence, and goes the earthly way assigned to him by God ... Jesus places himself in solidarity with the people by responding to the Baptist’s message the way Israel should respond, seeing that John came ‘in the way of righteousness’ (Matt. 21:32).”

The Apocalypse of Jesus

This short story is of momentous significance for Matthew's presentation of Jesus as both Israel's messianic deliverer and the divine glory of God become human. Matthew has taken up Mark's shorter presentation of this story and adapted a number of key words to make even more clear the Hebrew Bible echoes he wants us to hear.

Mark 1:10-11 Insutruactor's Translation

¹⁰ Immediately coming up out of the water, he saw the heavens being torn, and the Spirit like a dove descending unto him; ¹¹ and a voice came out of the heavens: "You are my beloved Son, in you I am well-pleased."

Matthew 3:16-17 NASB

¹⁶ After being baptized, Jesus came up immediately from the water; and behold, the heavens were opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming on him, ¹⁷ and behold, a voice out of the heavens said, "This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well-pleased."

Luke 3:21-22 NASB

²¹ Now when all the people were baptized, Jesus was also baptized, and while he was praying, heaven was opened, ²² and the Holy Spirit descended upon him in bodily form like a dove, and a voice came out of heaven, "You are my beloved Son, in you I am well-pleased."

Matthew has shifted the object of Jesus' seeing from Mark's "he saw the heavens opening and the Spirit ..." to focus Jesus' sight on seeing the Spirit as a dove, while the opening remains the scenic backdrop.

The imagery of the "opening of the heavens" is a key signal from Matthew that this narrative is an apocalypse, a moment where the veil between Heaven and Earth is opened (see also [Ezek. 1:1](#); [Acts 10:11](#); [Rev. 4:1](#), [19:11](#)).

Echoes of an Apocalypse

Matthew has received an earlier tradition about Jesus' baptism and lightly reshapes it in order to highlight a few features of the story. The main way the gospel authors help the reader see the meaning and significance of this story is by adopting specific words and imagery from important texts in the Hebrew Scriptures. By meditating on these echoes of Scripture, we can see what the gospels want us find here in this story.

Echo 1: Genesis, the Watery Cosmic Apocalypse

The cosmic water and bird imagery comes directly from Genesis 1:2, where God's Spirit is depicted as a bird hovering over the chaotic pre-creation waters. The Spirit of God's presence over the waters signals the transition from pre-creation chaos to the process of God's creative work by speaking his word.

Genesis 1:2-3 Instructor's Translation

2 Now, the land was wild and waste, and darkness was over the face of the abyss-waters,³ and the Spirit of Elohim was fluttering over the face of the waters, and God said, "Let there be light ..."

Genesis 8:8, 10, 12 Instructor's Translation

⁸ And he sent out a dove to see whether the waters had subsided from upon the face of the ground. ...

¹⁰ And he waited another seven days, and again he sent out the dove from the ark. ...

¹² And he waited seven more days, and he sent out the dove. But it did not return again to him.

The point: By echoing Genesis 1, Matthew is signalling that God is bringing about a new-creation act of cosmic importance. It will involve a reordering of creation on a scale similar to creation itself. By linking to the image of a dove, the story shows that the fluttering dove is a sign of re-creation after the long devastation of Israel's slavery to the nations.

"Jesus, the evangelists, and the early church utilized the dove, resonating within the denouement of Noah's story, to construe Jesus' baptism as the end of judgment, the reversal of exile, the new creation, and the opportunity to herald the good news of God's presence and Kingdom."

Capes, David. (1999). "Intertextual Echoes in the Matthean Baptismal Narrative," [*Bulletin for Biblical Research* vol. 9](#). 47.

Echo 2: The Open Heavens and the Resting Spirit

Isaiah 11:1-2 NASB

¹ Then a shoot will spring from the stem of Jesse,
and a branch from his roots will bear fruit.

² **The Spirit of Yahweh will rest on him,**
the spirit of wisdom and understanding,
the spirit of counsel and strength,
the spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord.

Isaiah 64:1 Instructor's Translation

Oh that you would **rip open the skies** and **come down** ...

Isaiah 11 and 64 both speak of future longing and hope for Israelites living under imperial occupation. Their hope was for a coming messianic deliverer from the lineage of King David (Isa. 11) who would be empowered by God's Spirit to bring justice and peace to the nations. And when the violent oppression of the nations seemed to be too much, the longing of God's people would erupt in cries for help (Isa. 64) that God would part the skies and come down.

Matthew wants us to see that Jesus' baptism is a transition moment in history, the moment when God "came down" in the form of the Father sending the Son and then sending the Spirit to empower the Son for his mission.

Echo 3: Ezekiel's Vision

Ezekiel 1:1 NASB

Now it came about in the thirtieth year, on the fifth day of the fourth month, while I was **by the river** Chebar among the exiles, **the heavens were opened** and **I saw visions of God**.

Ezekiel 2:2-3 LEB

² And **the Spirit came into me** as **he was speaking** to me, and it set me on my feet, and I heard **the one speaking** to me. ³ And he said to me, “**Son of adam**, I am sending you to the Israelites, to nations who are rebelling, who rebelled against me, they and their ancestors they transgressed against me until this very day.”

These passages in Ezekiel come from the prophet’s opening vision and call from God. Ezekiel was by a river in Babylon, and he described the divine presence as God’s Spirit who was sending him to a rebellious Israel. These are all relevant themes for Matthew’s presentation of Jesus, who also called himself the "Son of man" (i.e., Adam) sent to a rebellious Israel with a message of judgment and hope.

The Voice of the Father

	Mentioned in Genesis	Mentioned in the Rest of the Torah (Exodus- Deuteronomy)	The Prophets	The Writings	TaNaK as a Whole	New Testament
Abram	59x	0x	0x	2x		
Abraham	133x	18x	11x	13x		
	Total: 192x	Total: 18x	Total: 11x	Total: 15x	Total: 236x	Total: 73x
Jacob	180x	32x	98x	39x		
Israel	43x	544x	1,487x	432x		
	Total: 223x	Total: 576x	Total: 1,585x	Total: 471x	Total: 2,855x	Total: 27x

Yaaqov in Genesis and Hebrew Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The divine voice of the Father is a blend of three important moments from the Hebrew Bible, where the focus is on a divinely chosen figure who is pivotal for God's purposes.

- The Psalms 2 son of David: This calls up the promise of Genesis 3:15 about the seed of the woman who will crush the head of the snake, which leads all the way through Abraham and Judah to the line of David. Key texts here are 2 Samuel 7 and 1 Chronicles 17.
- The Genesis 22 beloved son of the father: This calls up the story of Abraham and Sarah's successes and failures in trusting God to provide them a son. Because of their sins against Hagar and Ishmael, God requests the life of the promised son, only to provide a substitute and give the beloved son back to his family as a gift.
- The Isaiah 42 servant of Yahweh: This figure is a composite character in Isaiah who is presented as a king, a prophet, and a priestly actor who will represent Israel's covenant before God and carry out his purpose to the nations.

The Seed of the Trinity

Notice how the baptism story presents the arrival of Israel's God (as John the Immerser announced) in a threefold manner: **The Father** communicates his love for **the Son** through the presence of **the Spirit**.

Readers of Matthew have long noticed that this implicit portrait of Israel's God as three-and-one is made explicit in the final paragraph of the Gospel, as Jesus invites his future apprentices to undergo a similar immersion and re-creation in baptism.

Matthew 28:18-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ And approaching, Jesus said to them,
"All authority in the sky and on the land has been given to me,
¹⁹ so then, when y'all go, make apprentices of all the nations,
immersing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
²⁰ teaching them to keep everything that I have commanded y'all;
and look, I am with y'all all of the days,
until the conclusion of the age."

Reflection Question

What three Hebrew Bible figures are called to mind when the voice from heaven proclaims, "This is my son, the beloved one, in him I have delight" (Matt. 3:17)?

Session 13: Jesus Tested in the Wilderness

Key Takeaways

- The Spirit leading Jesus into the wilderness signals an apocalyptic vision journey, like that of many other prophets before Jesus.
- Jesus' 40 days in the wilderness mirror Israel's 40 years in the wilderness.
- The slanderer's opening assault, "If you are the Son of God" (Matt. 4:3, 6), calls into question the identity that was affirmed in the previous story.
- The test about food is a choice, not about what is or isn't good, but about how and when you obtain the good—whether you will trust what God says in spite of appearances.

Jesus' Apocalyptic Journey

4:1 Then Jesus was led into the wilderness by **the spirit**,
to be tested by **the slanderer**,

Test 1

A ² and having **fasted** forty days and forty nights,
afterward he was **hungry**,

B ³ and approaching, **the tester** said to him,
" **If you are the son of God** ,
speak so that these stones become **loaves of bread**."

Deuteronomy 8:3

C ⁴ And responding, he said,
" **It has been written** ,
'Not by **bread** alone does humanity live,
but by every word that comes out from God's mouth.'"

Test 2

A' ⁵ Then **the slanderer** took him into **the holy city** ,
and he stationed him at the upper tip of **the temple** ,

⁶ and he said to him,
" **If you are the son of God** ,
throw yourself down,
B' **for it has been written** ,
'He has commanded his **messengers** concerning you,
and they will lift you up in their hands,
so that you won't strike your foot against a stone.'"

Deuteronomy 6:16

C' ⁷ Iesous said to him,
"Again, **it has been written** ,
'You will not **test** **the Lord your God** .'"

Test 3

A" ⁸ Again, **the slanderer** took him to **a high mountain** ,
and he showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor,

⁹ and he said to him,
B" "All these things I will give to you,
if, falling down, you will **bow down** to me."

Deuteronomy 6:13

¹⁰ Then Iesous said to him,
"Be gone, adversary!
C" For **it has been written** ,
'You will **bow down** to **the Lord your God** ,
and you will **serve** him only.'"

¹¹ Then **the slanderer** left him,
and look, **messengers** approached and ministered to him.

The primary setting for this story is “in the wilderness” ([Matt. 4:1](#)), but notice that he is also suddenly transported to Jerusalem and the temple building and then to a high mountain ([Matt. 4:5, 8](#)). A common feature of prophetic apocalypses in later biblical tradition portrays the seer being led about by the Spirit or angelic guides.

Ezekiel 8:1-3 NIV

¹In the sixth year, in the sixth month on the fifth day, while I was sitting in my house and the elders of Judah were sitting before me, the hand of the Sovereign LORD came on me there. ... ³ **The Spirit lifted me up between earth and heaven and in visions of God he took me to Jerusalem ...**

Ezekiel 11:24 NIV

The Spirit lifted me up and brought me to the exiles in Babylonia in the vision given by the Spirit of God.

Revelation 1:9-10 LEB

⁹ I, John, your brother and co-sharer in the affliction and kingdom and steadfastness in Jesus, was **on the island called Patmos** because of the word of God and the testimony about Jesus. ¹⁰ **I was in the Spirit on the Lord’s day**, and I heard behind me a great sound like a trumpet

Revelation 4:1-2 LEB

¹ After these things I looked, and behold, **an open door in heaven**, and the former voice that I had heard like a trumpet speaking with me was saying, “**Come up here** and I will show you the things which must take place after these things.” ² Immediately **I was in the Spirit**, and behold, a throne was set in heaven, and one was seated on the throne.

Prophets are taken on apocalyptic journeys in order to reveal something to them or so they can face a test of trust that will determine what role they will play in the divine purpose (as in Ezekiel’s experience in [Ezek. 1-3](#) or [Isa. 6](#)). In this case, Jesus is taken to the wilderness for a journey that will put to the test whether Jesus trusts his true identity and character as the beloved Son.

Tested by the Slanderer

Slanderer: The “devil” is a translation from the Greek *diabolos* (διαβολος), which means “the slanderer” or “the accuser.” This word refers to the function that this spiritual being has within the assumed imagery of God’s divine council (see [Job 1-2](#) or [1 Kgs. 22](#)). God’s heavenly council room is presumed to be filled with various courtiers, one of whom accuses God’s chosen one to have some fault. God allows his chosen one to undergo hardship that will put to the test their loyalty and commitment to their calling.

“Tested” (Grk. *peirazo* / πειραζω): In the Bible, the testing of someone’s character is something that is done both by the snake-slanderer (as in [Matt. 4:1](#), [Luke 22:31-32](#), or [Job 1-2](#)), but also by God (see [Gen. 22:1](#) or [Exod. 20:18-20](#)).

- “Test” means to prove the truth about something through an ordeal that displays its character.
- Test is a word that comes from the world of blacksmithing, metallurgy, and stone-working.

Zechariah 13:9 NASB

And I will bring the third part through the fire, refine them as silver is refined, and **test them as gold is tested**. They will call on my name, and I will answer them; I will say, “They are my people,” and they will say, “The LORD is my God.”

Isaiah 28:16 NASB

Therefore thus says the Lord God, “Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone, **a tested stone**, a costly cornerstone for the foundation, firmly placed. He who believes in it will not be disturbed.”

In this context the test is about “stress-testing” an object to determine its true nature or reliability.

However, the nature of a test is determined by the intentions of the tester.

- A test is a trap when the purpose of the tester is to cause failure.
- A test is an opportunity when the purpose of the tester is to provide an opportunity to grow.

Jesus’ Tested Vocation

The focus of the test is clearly on Jesus’ identity and vocation as the beloved Son of God.

“The meaning of the ‘temptation story’ is not so much that Jesus was put in the way of sin and resisted it; rather, the story is about Jesus’ acceptance of his mission ... The Jesus who confronts us is not simply the one who has been tempted, but the one who has emerged from his ordeal ... Jesus was tested to see whether he was prepared to renounce the easy way of power and public success and obediently tread the hard road marked out by Isaiah’s servant ... The ‘get behind me Satan’ ... remark shows that Jesus faced an ordeal that tried him to the uttermost.”

Jeremias, Joachim (2012). [New Testament Theology](#). SCM Press. 74-75.

“We must see in the three pictures that are set before us temptations which came to Jesus as he had become aware of his own high vocation; and we must also assume that he deemed his experience relevant to the hopes and desires of his disciples. Otherwise why should he have told it to them?”

Manson, T.W. (1977). [Servant-Messiah: A Study of the Public Ministry of Jesus](#). Baker Book House. 55.

“The heart of the temptation is to be found in an attempt to induce Jesus to be unfaithful to a pattern of Sonship conceived in terms of the relationship between ideal Israel and the divine Father. It is a temptation away from sonship ... Jesus was called to live out in his own experience the sonship that was to have characterized Israel, and relationship with God which involves (1) dependence on him for the provision of needs, (2) trust in his presence without the need for demonstration, and (3) acceptance of sovereignty only on his terms”

Donaldson, Terence (1987). [Jesus on the Mountain](#). Sheffield Academic Press. 100.

Jesus as Adam and Israel

Jesus’ test is portrayed on analogy to the tests of Adam and Eve in the garden and also to Israel’s test of trust in the wilderness. The reader is invited to compare these tests through a variety of clever textual signals and key images.

Jesus and Adam & Eve	Jesus and Israel
Adam & Eve were tested in a garden // Jesus is tested in the wilderness (opposite of a garden!)	Israel is tested in the wilderness for 40 years // Jesus is tested in the wilderness for 40 days
Adam & Eve were tested by the snake // Jesus is tested by the slanderer	Israel is tested by God // Jesus is tested by the slanderer (allowed by Jesus’ Father)
Adam & Eve were given a test of trust related to food (a fruit tree) // Jesus was tested in relation to food (bread)	Exod. 15:25; 16:4 Israel was tested to trust God for water and bread // Jesus is tested in relation to bread
Gen. 1:26-28 Adam & Eve's vocation as rulers of creation is put to the test // Jesus’ destiny to rule as Son of David/God is put to the test	Exod. 19:4-6 Israel’s vocation as a kingdom of priests is tested in the wilderness // Jesus’ vocation as the royal priest is put to the test
<i>Jesus as Adam and Israel.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

“Jesus, the Son of God, is repeating the experience of Israel in the desert. Having passed through the waters of a new exodus at his baptism, he enters the desert to suffer a time of testing, his forty days of fasting being analogous to Israel’s forty years of wandering. Like Israel, Jesus is tempted by hunger. And, like Israel, Jesus is tempted to idolatry. All-important for a right understanding of our pericope is Deut. 8:2–3: ‘And you shall remember all the way which the Lord your God has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you, testing you to know what was in your heart, whether you would keep his commandments, or not. And he humbled you and let you hunger ...’”

Davies, W.D. & Allison, Dale C. (2000). [A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel according to Saint Matthew, Volume 1](#). T&T Clark. 352.

Test #1: Stones and Bread

The tester questions Jesus’ recently announced identity, “If you are the son of God ...” If Jesus truly is the beloved Son of the Father, why on earth should he be going hungry in the desert? Surely the divine Son has the ability to meet his own needs.

This strongly echoes the snake’s words to the woman at the tree, which was an attack on the trustworthy character of God. “Did God really say don’t eat from any tree in the garden?”

Jesus trusts that his Father has a larger purpose in mind, as the larger context of his quotation from Deuteronomy 8 implies.

Deuteronomy 8:2-5 NIV

² Remember how the LORD your God led you all the way in the wilderness these forty years, to humble and test you in order to know what was in your heart, whether or not you would keep his commands. ³ He humbled you, causing you to hunger and then feeding you with manna, which neither you nor your ancestors had known, to teach you that man does not live on bread alone but on every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD. ⁴ Your clothes did not wear out and your feet did not swell during these forty years. ⁵ Know then in your heart that as a father disciplines his son, so the LORD your God disciplines you.

Jesus' trust in God's provision of bread in the desert is a deliberate replay of Israel's struggle to trust that God would provide daily manna bread in the desert (see Exod. 16 and Num. 11). The slanderer is trying to break Jesus' perfect trust in his Father's care.

Jesus does not say that we don't live by bread at all. Rather, he says that human life is ultimately sustained not only by bread, but by the word of God that provides bread in the first place. And it is to the word of God that Jesus will remain loyal.

"Since Jesus has been led by the Spirit into the wilderness, his fasting corresponds to the will of God. It would thus be a violation of his commitment to the will of God and deny his trust in God's care, if he were to ease his situation by acting on his own authority and change stones into bread ... Obedience to God's word, in which true life is to be found, is of controlling importance."

Konradt, Matthias (2020). [*The Gospel according to Matthew: A Commentary*](#). Baylor University Press. 54.

"Jesus understood his experience of hunger as God's will for him at the time, and therefore not to be evaded by a self-indulgent use of his undoubted power. As God's son, Jesus would trustingly and obediently comply with his father's purpose, as he will do again on the night in Gethsemane."

France, R.T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew*](#). Eerdmans. 131.

Test #2: Throw Yourself Down

Jesus' visionary tour takes him to the top of the temple in Jerusalem. He didn't actually climb up to the top. Jesus is still in apocalyptic visionary mode.

The temple's "upper tip" (Grk. *pterugion* / *πτερυγιον*) could technically refer to the highest point of the temple itself or perhaps the pinnacle of the pillared colonnade south of the temple proper that stood overlooking the valley below. Either way, it's a drop of some 150 feet.

"Throw yourself down ..." means deliberately create a situation in which the Father will be obligated to save the life of his Son. Instead of trusting the Father's timing for life or death, force God's hand, that is, test your Father's commitment to deliver and care for you as the divine Son.

In this way, Jesus would become the master of the Father, compelling God to act.

“That the Son of God can rely on God’s protection does not ... justify him in acting in such a way that God would be compelled to intervene ... This second temptation is forshadowing the passion story, for when he is arrested, Jesus rejects violent resistance from one of his disciples by pointing out that he could bring from his Father more than twelve legions of angels. But he must fulfill the will of God and thus take death upon himself for the sake of others.”

Konradt, Matthias (2020). [*The Gospel According to Matthew: A Commentary*](#). Baylor University Press. 55.

The slanderer quotes from [Psalm 91](#), but the whole context is illuminating.

Psalm 91:9-13 NIV*

⁹ If you say, “Yahweh is my refuge,”
and you make the Most High your dwelling,
¹⁰ no harm will overtake you,
no disaster will come near your tent.
¹¹ For he will command his angels concerning you
to guard you in all your ways;
¹² they will lift you up in their hands,
so that you will not strike your foot against a stone.
¹³ You will tread on the lion and the cobra;
you will trample the great lion and the serpent.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The slanderer is twisting this psalm, turning it from a promise of care and victory for the Davidic king into a formula that can be used to coerce the Father into action. Notice the mention of the snake in Psalm 91:13, as if the devil is luring Jesus into trying to conquer him.

Jesus’ counter-quotation comes from another story of Israel’s wilderness journey where God tested Israel’s trust when they lacked water in [Exodus 17:7](#).

Deuteronomy 6:16 NASB*

You shall not put Yahweh your God to the test, as you tested him at Massah.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“The father is not to be compelled. Rather every deed should be an obedient reaction to what he has willed. To use divine power in order to gain self-assurance or to prove what is known to faith, this Jesus cannot do. Any peril he must face and any miracle he is to do must arise solely from obedient service to God’s purpose. When the time comes, the Son will put his life on the line ... but the time is not yet.”

Davies, W.D. & Allison, Dale C. (2000). [*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel according to Saint Matthew, Volume 1*](#). T&T Clark. 367.

Test #3: Allegiance and Power

Here, the slanderer changes strategy and no longer tries to undermine Jesus' trust in his Father. He simply makes a bid for allegiance and power.

In the Hebrew Bible, universal dominion over the nations is a common theme in messianic imagery.

Psalm 2:7-8 LEB

⁷ I will tell the decree; Yahweh said to me: "You are my son; today I have begotten you.

⁸ Ask from me and **I will make the nations your heritage**, and your possession the ends of the earth."

Psalm 72:8-11 LEB

⁸ And **may he rule from sea up to sea**, and from the River to the edges of the land.

⁹ Let the desert dwellers bow down before him, and his enemies lick the dust.

¹⁰ Let the kings of Tarshish and the islands bring tribute. Let the kings of Sheba and Seba present gifts,

¹¹ and **let all kings bow down to him. Let all nations serve him.**

Daniel 7:13-14 LEB

¹³ I continued watching in the visions of the night, and look, with the clouds of heaven one like a son of man was coming, and he came to the Ancient of Days, and was presented before him. ¹⁴ And to him was given **dominion and glory and kingship that all the peoples, the nations, and languages would serve him**; his dominion is a dominion without end that will not cease, and his kingdom is one that will not be destroyed.

In the New Testament, the current dominion of the evil one over the nations is a common motif.

2 Corinthians 4:3-4 LEB

³ But if indeed our gospel is veiled, it is veiled among those who are perishing, ⁴ among whom **the god of this age** has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, so that they would not see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.

1 John 5:19 LEB

We know that we are from God, and **the whole world lies in the power of the evil one.**

John 12:31 LEB

Now is the judgment of this world! Now **the ruler of this world** will be thrown out!

Jesus is destined to become the messianic ruler of the world, and at the climax of his story he does in fact gain this very role on the last mountain in Matthew's account.

Matthew 28:16-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And the eleven apprentices went unto Galilaia,
unto the mountain which Iesus arranged with them. ...

¹⁸ And approaching, Iesus said to them,
"All authority in the sky and on the land has been given to me,

¹⁹ so then, when y'all go, make apprentices of **all the nations**,
immersing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
²⁰ teaching them to keep everything that I have commanded y'all;
and look, I am with y'all all of the days,
until the conclusion of the age."

The story's conclusion makes clear that Jesus' test is not about whether he will assume cosmic rule over the nations but, instead, his test is about how he will come into that power. How will he gain that power? Will he do it by giving allegiance to his Father or by the more typical ways that humans come into their power and influence? The deeper meaning of this test and Jesus' response is illuminated by two key hyperlinks in this test. The first is the source of Jesus' quotation from Deuteronomy.

Deuteronomy 6:12-14 LEB

¹² then take care for yourself, so that you do not forget Yahweh, who brought you out from the land of Egypt from the house of slavery. ¹³ **You shall fear Yahweh your God, and you shall serve him**, and by his name you shall swear. ¹⁴ You shall not go after other gods from the gods of the peoples who are all around you,

Also crucial is the one other time that Jesus will use the phrase "go away, satan!" (Grk. *υπαγε, σατανα*)

Matthew 4:9-10 NASB

⁹ and he said to him, "All these things I will give you, if you fall down and worship me." ¹⁰ Then Jesus said to him, **"Go away, Satan!** For it is written, 'You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve him only.'"

Matthew 16:22-23 NASB*

²² Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him, saying, "God forbid it, Lord! This shall never happen to you." ²³ But he turned and said to Peter, **"Go away, Satan!** You are a stumbling block to me; for you are not setting your mind on God's interests, but man's."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jesus hears the voice of the deceiver in the voice of Peter at precisely the moment that Jesus predicted that the Son of Man, who is destined to rule the world, will come into his power by giving up his life for others.

Here in the desert, Jesus wrestles with his vocation to suffer and die in the supreme act of trust that his Father will vindicate him and raise him up to a place of authority and power on the other side of death.

To use the typical human means of gaining power through coercion or violence, to avoid death by fighting or sidelining one's enemies, this would be to "fall down and worship" the evil one. It is only by surrendering to the mysterious will of the Father, even if that should mean death and loss, that Jesus will take up his true calling as THE human image of God.

The Defeated Devil Departs

The slanderer "left" Jesus (Grk. *aphiemi* / *αφιημι*), i.e., "abandoned, released."

After this point, the slanderer has no power or claim on Jesus, and has been defeated as far as Jesus' own will is concerned. This victory is demonstrated narratively through Jesus' exorcisms and healing, as he is able to deliver others from sickness and death because of his own power over the snake. Jesus explicitly said this is what he was doing, plundering the house of a "strong man" to snatch his belongings.

Matthew 12:28-29 Instructor's Translation

²⁸ But **if I throw out *daimons* by means of God's Spirit,**

then, therefore, the kingdom of God has arrived upon you;

²⁹ or, how is someone able to enter into the house of strong-one,

and snatch his belongings,

unless he first binds up the strong-one?

Then he can plunder his house.

Now the only power the slanderer has over Jesus will be through deceiving others, like Judas (see [John 13:2](#)) or Peter (see [Luke 22:31](#)), and ultimately by deceiving the powers that will kill Jesus.

Jesus moves on from this victory describing the Satan as a defeated enemy as far as he's concerned. This victory in the wilderness is what frees Jesus to set others free from his power. And that, of course, is what the next and final unit of Matthew's introduction is all about.

Reflection Question

What are some ways that Jesus' wilderness testing mirrors stories from the Hebrew Bible?

Session 14: Jesus Passes the Test

Key Takeaways

- In the second test, the slanderer tempts Jesus to exert control and make the Father do what he said he would.
- Jesus' third test is not about whether he will assume cosmic rule over the nations, but about how he will come into that power.
- Jesus' three wilderness tests correspond to his three prayers in the garden of Gethsemane. The garden is where he completes the test that started in the desert.
- Jesus, the Son of God, is a new Adam and Eve, a new David, and a new Israel—he succeeds where they failed.



This session covers the notes from session 13

Reflection Question

What is being tested in the slanderer's temptation for Jesus to cast himself down from the highest point of the temple?

Session 15: Jesus' Kingdom Mission

Key Takeaways

- The two-sentence summary of Matthew 4:17, "Change course! The Kingdom of the skies has come near," encapsulates the core of what Jesus preaches throughout his ministry.
- Matthew adapts quotes from the Psalms and Prophets by using key words from other texts to highlight a network of connected passages.
- The most unexpected aspects of Jesus' message about the Kingdom are not its ideals, but the people to and through whom that Kingdom will come and what it will look like when it arrives.

Matthew 4:12-17

¹² Now, when he heard that **Ioannes** had been handed over, he departed into **Galilaia**,
¹³ and having left Nazara, coming he dwelt in Kapharnaoum **beside the sea**, in the regions of **Zaboulon and Nephthalim**,

¹⁴ so that **what was spoken through Esaias the prophet would be fulfilled**, saying,

¹⁵ "Land of **Zaboulon** and land of **Nephthalim**, path of **the sea**, **beyond the Iordanes**, **Galilaia** of the nations,

a ¹⁶ the people **sitting in darkness**,

b **a great light** they have seen,

a' and to those sitting in a country and shadow of **death**,

b' **a light has east-arisen** on them."

¹⁷ From then on, Iesous began to announce and say,
"Change-direction!
Because **the kingdom of** **the skies** has come near!"

This unit picks up the theme of Jesus’ geographical movement from Matthew 3:13-4:11.

- Jesus arrives to see John at the Jordan river (Matt. 3:13-17).
- Jesus goes to the wilderness (Matt. 4:1).
- Jesus hears about John and retreats to Galilee (Matt. 4:12).
- Jesus leaves Nazareth and goes to live by the sea of Galilee (Matt. 4:13).

These movements help us see the design structure of this section, which consists of three short panels.

- A - v. 12-13: Jesus hears about John and moves from Nazareth to live by the sea
 - B - v. 14-16: How Jesus’ choice fulfills the Scriptures
- A’ - v. 17: Jesus’ message (= John’s) once he comes to live by the sea: The Kingdom of God is here!

Darkness and Light and the Sea

Matthew signals a major shift in the story with this seventh and final “fulfillment” quotation from the Scriptures. The quotation comes from Isaiah, just like the first quotation back in Matthew 1:23 (from Isa. 7:14), and so Matthew forms an inclusio frame around all seven of the quotations with the words of Isaiah, now from Isaiah 9:1-2.

Matthew adapts the wording of Isaiah 9:1-2 to fit with the main themes he wants to highlight from this moment in Jesus’ mission.

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in Original Languages (Masoretic Hebrew Texts & Old Greek)	Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in English
כי לא מועף לאשר מוצק לה²³ כעת הראשון הקל ארצה זבלון וארצה נפתלי והאחרון הכביד דרך הים עבר הירדן גליל הגוים: העם ההלכים בחשך¹ ראו אור גדול ישבי בארץ צלמות אור נגה עליהם:	For there will be no gloom for the one who was in distress As in the time of the beginning, he humiliated the land of Zevulun and the land of Naphtali, but in the end he has honored the way of the Sea, across the Jordan, Galilee of the nations, and the people walking in the darkness, they have seen a great light, those sitting in the land of deep-darkness a light has shone upon them.
Isaiah Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in Original Languages (Masoretic Hebrew Texts & Old Greek)

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in English

²³ και ουκ απορηθησεται ο εν στενοχωρια ων
εως καιρου.
Τουτο πρωτον ποιει, ταχυ ποιει,
χωρα Ζαβουλων, η γη Νεφθαλιμ
οδον θαλασσης **και οι λοιποι οι την**
παραλιαν
κατοικουντες και πρραν του Ιορδανου,
Γαλιλαια των εθνων
¹ ο λαος ο **πορευομενος** εν σκοτει,
ιδετε φως μεγα,
οι **κατοικουντες** εν χωρα και σκια θανατου,
φως **λαμψει** εφ' υμας.

and he will not be perplexed, the one in distress,
for a time,
Do this first, do it quickly,
region of Zaboulon, land of Nephtholim,
the way of the sea, **and those left living by the**
coast and beyond the Jordan,
Galilee of the nations,
the people **walking** in darkness,
look, a great light,
those **dwelling** in the region and shadow of
death,
a light **will shine upon** them,

Matthew 4:15–16

¹⁵ **Γη** Ζαβουλων καὶ γη Νεφθαλιμ,
οδον θαλασσης, -----
περαν του Ιορδανου,
Γαλιλαια των εθνων,
¹⁶ ο λαος ο **καθημενος** εν σκοτει
φως **ειδεν** μεγα,
και τοις **καθημενοις** εν χωρα και σκια
θανατου
φως **ανετειλεν** αυτοις.

Land of Zaboulon and land of Nephtholim,
way of the sea, -----
beyond the Jordan,
Galilee of the nations,
the people **sitting** in darkness,
they have seen a great light,
and those **sitting** the region and shadow of
death,
a light **rises on** them,

Isaiah Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Matthew's quotation does not precisely match either the Masoretic Hebrew text or the Old Greek Septuagint. His quotation shows some unique agreements with one against the other, which complicates the typical assumption that the New Testament authors simply read and quoted from the Greek Septuagint.

- Agreements with the Hebrew against the Greek
 - "land of Zebulun" (w/ Hebrew) instead of "region of Zaboulon" (Greek)
 - "they have seen" (w/ Hebrew) instead of "look!" (Greek)
 - "sitting in the region" (w/ Hebrew) instead of "dwelling" (Greek)
- Disagreements with both Hebrew and Greek
 - "sitting in darkness" (Matthew's Greek) vs. "walking in darkness" (Hebrew and Greek)
 - "a light rises on them" (Matthew's Greek) vs. "shines on them" (Hebrew and Greek)

Isaiah 9 Blended With Isaiah 42 and Isaiah 60

There are two places in Matthew's quotation of [Isaiah 9](#) that disagree with both the Hebrew and Greek traditions.

1. The people are described as "sitting" (καθηναι) in darkness, as opposed to "walking" (הלך or πορευω).
2. The light is described as "rising" (ανατελλω) upon the nations, instead of "shining" (הגה or λαμπω).

This is another place where Matthew has blended together the key words of multiple hyperlinked texts that are thematically related and hyperlinked within the composition of Isaiah, namely 42:6-7 and 60:1-2.

Isaiah 42:1-9 LEB

¹ Look! **Here is my servant**; I hold him,
my chosen one, in whom my soul delights.

I have put my spirit on him;

he will bring justice forth to the nations. ...

⁶ ... and I have given you as a covenant of the people, **as a light** of the nations,

⁷ to open the blind eyes,

to bring the prisoner out from the dungeon,

those sitting (ישב / καθηναι) **in darkness** from the house of imprisonment.

⁸ I am Yahweh, that is my name,

and I do not give my glory to another, nor my praise to the idols.

⁹ Look! the former things have come,
and I declare new things.

I announce them to you **before they rise up** (ανατελλω).

Isaiah 60:1-3 LEB

¹ Arise, shine! For **your light** has come,
and the glory of Yahweh **has risen** (זרר / ανατελλω) on you.

² For look! **Darkness** shall cover the earth,
and thick **darkness the peoples**,
but Yahweh will shine on you,
and his glory will appear over you.

³ And nations shall come to your light,
and kings to the bright light of your sunrise.

In both passages, a divine light shines on the nations through God's servant ([Isa. 42](#)) or upon the new Jerusalem ([Isa. 60](#)), and the nations come (linked to [Isa. 2:1-5](#)) and find God's justice and instruction that leads to life and freedom, not just from imperial oppression, but from death itself.

Messianic Hope: Isaiah 9 in the Context of Isaiah

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 is one small snippet of a cycling set of themes within [Isaiah 1-12](#), specifically within [Isaiah 6:1-9:6](#).

	Israel's Rebellion	Time of Divine Judgment	Time of Divine Salvation
Isaiah 6	Israel's "hard" heart/blind/deaf	Exile and devastation of Judah	Holy seed remains
Isaiah 7	Ahaz' rejection of Isaiah's "sign"	Assyrian devastation of Judah	Immanuel and remnant
Isaiah 8-9	Isa. 8:11 "the way of this people"	Stumbling, shattering, darkness	• Light, defeated oppressor • Messianic king!
Isaiah 8:16-9:1	• Isaiah's prophetic message rejected • Isa. 8:16-18 Sealed scroll passed on to disciples	• Period of "waiting" • Isa. 9:1a "the former time"	• Fulfillment of divine promise! • Isa. 9:1b "the latter time"

Isaiah 9's Context in Isaiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Within this section, a series of poetic sequences culminate with the anticipation of a future “seed” who will signal the restoration of Israel and the time of divine salvation. The reader is meant to meditate on the relationship between the poetic images: holy seed ([Isa. 6:12-13](#)), the Immanuel child ([Isa. 7:14](#)), the arrival of God’s creative light, and the birth of a divine-child-savior ([Isa. 9:5-6](#)).

Within the larger frame of the book of Isaiah, all of these promises of divine salvation culminate in the deliverance of Jerusalem in the days of Hezekiah ([Isa. 36-39](#)). The story of the city’s deliverance is the pivot of the entire scroll, making up the central literary movement.

Chapters	Content	Literary Type
Isa. 1-12	Jerusalem rebels, is judged, but a remnant is redeemed	Poetry + Narrative [Ahaz]
Isa. 13-27	God topples the nations while preserving a remnant	Poetry
Isa. 28-35	Jerusalem to be destroyed, but a remnant delivered	Poetry

Isaiah Literary Movements. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Chapters	Content	Literary Type
Isa. 36-39	Jerusalem saved from Assyria > Babylonian exile predicted	Narrative + Poetry [Hezekiah]
Isa. 40-48	Israel called out of Babylon as a witness to the nations	Poetry
Isa. 49-55	God calls a servant to act on behalf of rebellious Israel	Poetry
Isa. 56-66	Promise of the new Jerusalem for all nations	Poetry
<i>Isaiah Literary Movements. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>		

However, after the city's great deliverance in Isaiah [36-38](#), [chapter 39](#) comes along as a great test-and-failure narrative, where King Hezekiah attempts to ally with the Babylonians and dishonors the house of God. His failure generates hope for a future figure who will become the true fulfillment of the messianic hopes of chapters 1-12 sometime after the Babylonian era. Matthew, who perceives the future-pointing momentum of Isaiah's promises, applies these hopes to Jesus.

Another key metaphor in Isaiah is that of God's wisdom and salvation depicted as a period of darkness and shining light.

The image of darkness as a symbol of divine judgment begins in [Isaiah 5:30](#) and [Isaiah 8:22](#), and the image of light is introduced in [Isaiah 2:1-5](#) and then developed in [Isaiah 8:23-9:2](#). These twin symbols develop side by side throughout the book (see [Isa. 30:26](#); [42:6-7](#), [16](#); [45:7](#); [49:9](#); [51:4](#); [58:10](#); [59:9](#)) and culminate in the great triad of new Jerusalem poems in [Isaiah 60-62](#) (see [Isa. 60:1-2](#), [19-20](#)).

What's the Point of the Fulfillment Quotation?

Matthew's goal is to show how Jesus' arrival onto the scene in Galilee is the reality anticipated by Israel's covenant story. Specifically, he is the divine-human messianic deliverer from the line of David, and he is also the divine, heavenly light shining on those in darkness.

Notice that the theme of "light" and "shining" has been a major theme in all of Matthew 1-4.

- The angels "appeared shining" ([φαινω](#) in [Matt. 1:20](#); [2:13](#), [19](#)).
- The magi come from the "sunrise-east" ([ανατολη](#) in [Matt. 2:1](#)).
- The magi saw a "star in the sunrise-east" ([αστηρ ανατολη](#) in [Matt. 2:2](#), [9-10](#)).
- The magi's star "appeared shining" ([φαινω](#) in [Matt. 2:7](#)).
- Jesus' arrival by the sea is a "great light" that "sun-rises" ([ανατελλω](#)) on Gailiee ([Matt. 4:16](#)).

Matthew also focuses on the theme of Jesus' Davidic heritage and ancestry throughout all of Matthew 1-4 as well (the genealogy, Joseph as son of David, the Immanuel promise, the [Micah 5](#) quotation).

In portraying Jesus as the divine-human Davidic king who brings God's light into the world, Matthew continues a core theme that already existed within Isaiah. Not only that, Matthew shapes the introduction to his Gospel account in ways that apply these specific images to Jesus. It is this type of dialogue between the apostles and prophets that we see all over the New Testament. The Hebrew Scriptures are not simply a reservoir of symbols and predictions that the apostles apply to Jesus, they have also meditated on the meaning of Jesus in light of the Hebrew Scriptures and written their accounts to show the deep continuity that exists between the two.

Jesus and the Kingdom of God

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Jesus began
to announce and say,
"Change-direction!
Because **the kingdom of the skies** has come near!"

With these words we come to a major pivot in the storyline of Matthew's Gospel, and the large section of 3:1-4:17 draws to a close. Jesus' arrival onto the scene was prefaced by John the Immerser's mission ([Matt. 3:1-12](#)), and Jesus' baptism signals the passing of the baton, so to speak, from John to Jesus. Jesus then entered into the wilderness where his identity (as the Son of God) and vocation (to bring God's heavenly Kingdom) were tested, and he passed the test successfully. After doing so, Jesus relocated to the sea of Galilee and began his mission to announce that God's reign was arriving on Earth in and through himself.

This is a pivotal and programmatic line, signaling an important transition in the story, as Jesus passes from his "preparation" period into the first stage of his mission as Son of God.

Long ago, Jack Kingsbury noticed that this key line is matched at one other macro-structural hinge moment in Matthew's story (see his [Matthew: Structure, Christology, Kingdom](#), chapter 1).

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Jesus began (απο τότε ηρξατο ο Ιησους)
to announce and say
"Change-direction!
Because the kingdom of the skies has come near!"

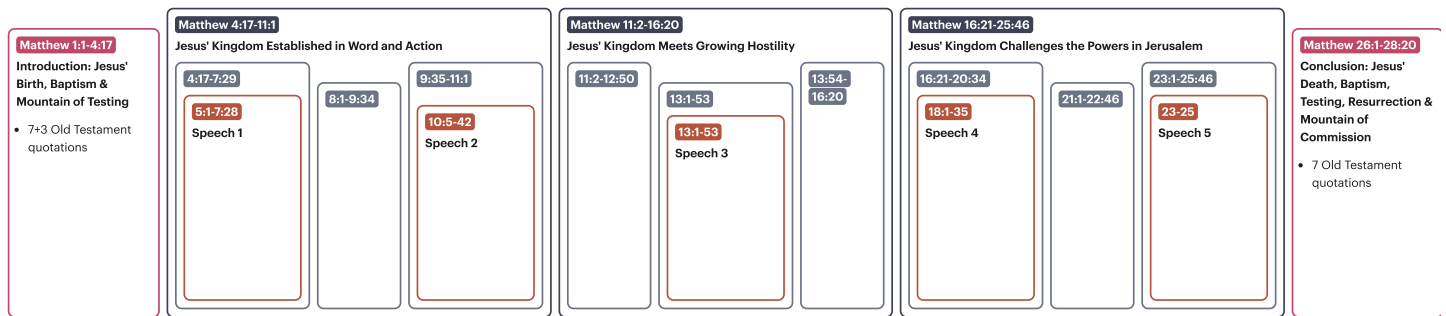
Matthew 16:21 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Jesus began (απο τότε ηρξατο ο Ιησους)
to point out that it was necessary for him to go to Jerusalem,
and to suffer many things by the elders and chief-priests and scribes,
and to be killed,
and on the third day, to be raised up,

It is important to note that in the macro-structure of Matthew, these two scenes come at precisely matching moments in Jesus' messianic journey.

1. His transition from a period of preparation in Nazareth and the wilderness into a period of announcing the Kingdom of God in the region of Galilee (Matt. 4:12-16:20)
2. His transition from announcing God's Kingdom in Galilee to the long journey to Jerusalem where he will challenge the powers in the city and temple (Matt. 16:21-28:20)

It is no coincidence that these two moments are matching macro-structural hinges that simultaneously conclude and introduce the next section of Matthew's account. These matching transitions appear at the beginning of the first and last major parts of the central core that makes up Matthew 4:12-25:46, making Galilee and Jerusalem the central focus points of the story.



Matthew 1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Reflection Question

How would you unpack the two-sentence summary of Jesus' message, "Repent, for the Kingdom of Heaven has come near"?

Session 16: Reflecting on Matthew 1-4

Key Takeaways

- Matthew's use of Hebrew Bible quotes invites us to meditate on—that is, to read and reread—the unified story of the Bible through the revealing lens of Jesus coming to this world.
- The Bible continually offers ways to see the familiar in new, unfolding layers of depth and meaning.
- This text is not just about words, it's about people. It was created in community and was intended to be studied in community and to lead us to a person.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Take some time to reflect on the insights you learned in this class.